

Partisan Favoritism in Public Spending: Evidence from Congressional Earmarks*

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Abstract

We study whether members of Congress use federal spending to favor co-partisan voters. Pairing an original, geocoded dataset covering U.S. earmark requests and allocations since the resumption of earmarking in FY2022 with a regression discontinuity design in House general elections, we find strong evidence of partisan favoritism. Narrowly electing a Democrat rather than a Republican shifts the average requested earmark dollar toward areas that are 8 percentage points more Democratic and increases the share of requested dollars to Democratic strongholds by 20 percentage points. This disparity persists across policy areas, is not explained by socio-demographic correlates of partisanship, extends beyond close elections, and carries through to enacted spending. Our results show that—rather than broadening representation—electoral incentives can push legislators to serve their supporters at the expense of their broader constituency.

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1 Introduction

If politics is about “who gets what, when, and how” (Lasswell, 1936), then a fundamental question of political representation is which constituents receive public resources. While representatives are elected to govern on behalf of entire constituencies, they depend electorally on only a subset of the electorate, creating incentives to reward those who helped elect them. Representation may therefore carry unequal material benefits within a constituency, advantaging co-partisans while leaving the opposition behind. We refer to such imbalances in distributive outcomes as partisan favoritism—the allocation of resources in ways that disproportionately benefit co-partisan constituents over others.¹

Do members of Congress favor co-partisan constituents when allocating federal spending? While a rich literature shows that electoral incentives shape how much effort legislators devote to securing distributive benefits for their districts (Levitt and Snyder Jr, 1995; Bickers and Stein, 1996; Balla et al., 2002; Lee, 2003; Lazarus, 2009; Engstrom and Vanberg, 2010; Albouy, 2013; Dynes and Huber, 2015; Berry and Fowler, 2016; Fagan et al., 2023), we have little evidence on whether they favor co-partisan constituents *within* the districts they represent once those benefits are secured.² Identifying such favoritism is difficult because it is challenging to distinguish legislators’ choices from the many differences between the districts that elect Democrats and Republicans.³ Further, because most federal spending is filtered through formula-based rules and shaped by legislative bargaining, realized spending rarely allows us to isolate individual legislators’ distributive priorities (Hammond and Rosenstiel, 2020).

We overcome these challenges by pairing new data on federal spending with a natural experiment. To isolate individual legislators’ spending priorities, we examine congressional earmarks, a discretionary mechanism through which individual members of Congress request funding for specific projects in their districts outside standard formula-based or competitive allocation processes. Crucially, the earmark process allows us to observe not only which projects ultimately receive funding, but also the projects each legislator requests and the

¹Our outcome-based definition of partisan favoritism parallels the notion of discrimination in law and economics, which is identified by disparate impact—an outcome that disadvantages one group net of legitimate justifications—rather than by demonstrable intent. Favoritism is thus the co-partisan–opposition disparity in outcomes, regardless of whether it arises from animus or from legislator strategy.

²Evidence of partisan favoritism comes largely from studies of presidential influence over federal spending (Kiewiet and McCubbins, 1988; McCarty, 2000; Garrett and Sobel, 2003; Larcinese et al., 2006; Bertelli and Grose, 2009; Healy and Malhotra, 2009; Berry et al., 2010; Kriner and Reeves, 2015; Lowande et al., 2018). However, it remains unclear whether the patterns they identify extend to Congress, which holds the power of the purse.

³For example, Democratic legislators may represent districts where necessary and fundable projects are disproportionately located in Democratic areas, while Republican members represent electorates where plausible earmark opportunities are in Republican areas, creating an association between legislator party and the partisan geography of requests absent partisan targeting.

requested amount. Beginning in fiscal year (FY) 2022, members of Congress must publicly disclose the project, recipient, amount, and location of each earmark request they make.⁴ We assemble these disclosures, together with enacted earmark allocations, into an original, geocoded dataset covering FY2022–FY2026, which allows us to observe the geography of discretionary spending below the district level. To then distinguish legislators’ targeting choices from the underlying differences between Democratic- and Republican-represented districts, we adopt a regression discontinuity (RD) design in U.S. House general elections (Lee, 2008). Near the close-election cutoff, the underlying geography of fundable projects and constituent needs varies smoothly, while the party of the elected representative changes discontinuously. Our design therefore identifies the effect of narrowly electing a Democrat rather than a Republican on the within-district partisan geography of requested and allocated earmarks (or vice versa).

We find clear evidence of co-partisan favoritism. Narrowly electing a Democrat rather than a Republican shifts the average requested earmark dollar to areas with a 4–8 percentage point higher Democratic registration share. This shift reflects a reallocation between partisan strongholds, rather than a uniform tilt across the district: electing a Democrat raises the share of requested earmark dollars flowing to Democratic strongholds—defined as areas with more than 60% Democratic registrants—by roughly 20 percentage points, while reducing the share directed to Republican strongholds by 11 percentage points. These reallocations are economically substantial in addition to being politically significant. In dollar terms, the effects we identify are equivalent to roughly \$15 million reallocated from opposition- to co-partisan-heavy areas per district-election cycle. In addition, by matching earmark requests to final appropriations bills, we also show that the partisan favoritism in legislators’ initial requests persists at nearly the same magnitude in enacted earmark spending.

We then assess whether this pattern reflects partisan differences in policy priorities or the targeting of socio-demographic groups correlated with party affiliation. To assess the first possibility, we classify earmark requests into eleven policy areas and re-estimate the RD separately for each category. We find evidence of partisan favoritism in ten of eleven policy areas, indicating that our headline effects are not driven by differences in policy priorities between Democratic and Republican legislators. Second, we replace local party registration with other characteristics of the nearby population that are known correlates of partisan preferences, including racial composition, population density, poverty, and educational attainment. Although Democratic representation also shifts requests toward some groups that are more likely to support Democrats, targeting on the basis of these socio-demographic characteristics is substantially smaller than targeting on the basis of partisanship.

⁴In the post-moratorium era starting FY2022, the House revived earmarks under the label “Community Project Funding” (CPF). We henceforth refer to these projects as earmarks.

To extend our analysis beyond the subset of districts featuring close elections, we complement our RD design with a panel of fixed 5-mile grid cells whose party representation changes over time, either due to electoral turnover or the 2022 decennial redistricting process. In this design, partisan composition remains the only characteristic that significantly predicts which neighborhoods gain additional earmarks when representation changes hands. Together, these results suggest that our central estimates reflect a distinct partisan component in earmark targeting rather than broad partisan differences in policy priorities or socio-demographic targeting.

Finally, we adjudicate whether this favoritism reflects the targeting of core or swing co-partisans (Cox and McCubbins, 1986; Lindbeck and Weibull, 1987; Dixit and Londregan, 1996). Using individual donors as a proxy for legislators’ core supporters, we find no evidence that legislators target core co-partisan constituents. Whereas narrow Democratic victories shift earmark dollars toward areas with more Democratic voters, they do not shift dollars toward areas with more Democratic donors. Thus, our results are more consistent with legislators targeting swing co-partisans rather than rewarding their partisan core.

Overall, our findings show that U.S. House members direct greater discretionary resources towards co-partisan constituents. More broadly, our paper illustrates that co-partisan representation carries material benefits, shaping which constituents receive more from government, in ways that other group identities do not.

Our findings advance the study of distributive politics and partisan representation in three ways. First, to our knowledge, we provide the first causal test of co-partisan favoritism on the within-district geography of U.S. House spending. Prior research on distributive spending by members of Congress has largely examined how resources are allocated across districts, but these studies cannot speak to whether the resulting benefits are broadly shared within constituencies or concentrated among politically favored groups (Cox and McCubbins, 1986; Lindbeck and Weibull, 1987; Dixit and Londregan, 1996).⁵ Building on studies of the first post-moratorium appropriations cycle (Cassella et al., 2023; Fagan et al., 2023; Kaslovsky and Stone, 2025), we assemble the first comprehensive, geocoded dataset of House earmarks covering every fiscal year since FY2022. This allows us to analyze the within-district geography of congressional spending directly—a question that existing data have rarely allowed researchers to address. Moreover, by studying both requests and allocations, we are able to isolate legislators’ distributive priorities before they are shaped by downstream bargaining and assess whether those priorities persist into enacted spending.

Second, our paper contributes to research on representation in American politics by identifying a material return to co-partisan representation. Existing research finds that

⁵The closest analogues examine senators’ within-state or county-level targeting strategies (Martin, 2003; Kaslovsky, 2022; Kaslovsky and Stone, 2025).

voters prefer to be represented by co-partisans, a preference often understood in terms of shared ideological preferences or expressive partisan attachments (Broockman and Ryan, 2016; Mummolo et al., 2021). Our findings identify an additional instrumental basis for this preference: voters stand to gain materially when represented by a co-partisan. Elections therefore determine not only who represents a district, but which constituents receive material benefits.

Finally, our findings complicate a common understanding of democratic accountability. Many theories suggest that elections—especially competitive ones—motivate politicians to work harder, adopt more responsive positions, and deliver for their districts. Empirical evidence that politicians are punished for ideological extremism or poor performance is therefore often interpreted as evidence that electoral competition should induce better representation. Yet this interpretation generally carries an implicit assumption that politicians who work hard for their districts are working for the district as a whole. Our results challenge that assumption. Even in the most electorally competitive districts, representatives direct more earmark dollars toward co-partisan communities than toward out-party communities within the same district. Electoral competition may therefore encourage legislative effort without ensuring equal representation.

This paper proceeds as follows. The next section reviews the literature on distributive politics in U.S. federal spending. Section 3 provides background on congressional earmarks and introduces our new dataset of geocoded earmark requests and allocations. Section 4 outlines our regression discontinuity design which uses U.S. House general elections. Section 5 presents our main results, showing that narrow partisan control shifts earmark dollars toward co-partisan areas within districts. Section 6 distinguishes partisan favoritism from partisan differences in policy priorities and socio-demographic targeting, and assesses whether the favoritism we document reflects the targeting of core or swing co-partisans. Section 7 concludes.

2 Distributive Politics and Political Favoritism

Elections create incentives for politicians to use public resources strategically. Foundational work in the modern study of distributive politics has origins in studies of Congress, where scholars linked legislative behavior to electoral incentives (Mayhew, 1974; Fenno, 1978). Early studies of congressional spending showed that legislators often sought re-election by “bringing home” federal dollars, known as “pork,” to their districts and claiming credit for these distributive benefits (Ferejohn, 1974; Fiorina, 1977; Cain et al., 1987).

This central insight raises a natural question about which voters politicians target with

these resources. Formal models of distributive politics offer competing predictions: politicians may reward core supporters, reinforcing the coalitions that brought them to office (Cox and McCubbins, 1986), or target swing voters, whose support can be shifted more efficiently with distributive spending (Lindbeck and Weibull, 1987). Subsequent theoretical work shows that these incentives depend on politicians’ ability to identify voter needs, deliver benefits effectively, and claim credit for them (Stein and Bickers, 1994; Dixit and Londregan, 1996, 1998; Stokes, 2005). Together, these debates motivate a broader empirical question about whether there is systematic favoritism in distributive spending (Golden and Min, 2013). Across a wide range of countries and comparative contexts, research finds that politicians direct greater public resources toward co-ethnics, co-partisans, or otherwise politically valuable in-group members (Chandra, 2004; Franck and Rainer, 2012; Jablonski, 2014; Hodler and Raschky, 2014; Burgess et al., 2015; Ejdemo et al., 2018; De Luca et al., 2018; Dreher et al., 2019; Colonnelli et al., 2020).

Scholars in the U.S. likewise find evidence of political favoritism in federal spending. Presidency scholars have shown that American presidents consistently use their influence to direct federal dollars towards co-partisan areas (Kiewiet and McCubbins, 1988; McCarty, 2000; Larcinese et al., 2006; Bertelli and Grose, 2009; Berry et al., 2010; Kriner and Reeves, 2015). For instance, U.S. presidents are more likely to allocate disaster spending (Garrett and Sobel, 2003; Healy and Malhotra, 2009; Reeves, 2011) or extend trade protection (Lowande et al., 2018) to electorally important constituencies.

It is less clear if similar patterns emerge in congressional spending,⁶ but whether members of Congress exhibit partisan favoritism is critical for understanding representation in the U.S. because Congress possesses the power of the purse. Past research on congressional spending primarily examines how factors such as electoral competition, majority-party status, seniority, and committee membership affect legislators’ ability and incentives to bring more resources home (Stein and Bickers, 1994; Levitt and Snyder Jr, 1995; Bickers and Stein, 1996; Martin, 2003; Albouy, 2013; Dynes and Huber, 2015; Berry and Fowler, 2016; Hammond and Rosenstiel, 2020). However, few have studied where those resources go within districts once they are secured. Because members of Congress represent entire districts, increased district-level spending cannot reveal whether resources benefit the constituency broadly or favor some groups over others.⁷ Evaluating partisan favoritism in the U.S. Congress instead requires observing within-district targeting strategies, which existing congressional spending data rarely permit.

⁶For example, presidential and congressional elections create different geographic incentives for targeting. Presidents may concentrate resources in electorally pivotal states because many states are safely Democratic or Republican and electoral votes are awarded on a winner-take-all basis. Members of Congress, by contrast, depend on support across a single district, making the relevant targeting problem less straightforward.

⁷This is a point made explicitly by Cox (2009). See page 346.

Congressional earmark requests offer a way to observe these within-district choices. Like the research on general congressional spending, early studies of earmarks primarily examine allocations across districts (Bickers and Stein, 2000; Balla et al., 2002; Lee, 2003; Lazarus, 2009; Engstrom and Vanberg, 2010; Clemens et al., 2015), leaving them unable to speak directly to whether political favoritism exists within districts. More recent studies using contemporary earmark request data examine the partisan dynamics of earmarking rather than distributive targeting (Cassella et al., 2023; Fagan et al., 2023). Our study is closest to Kaslovsky and Stone (2025), who examine senators’ within-state targeting in FY2022 and find that they request more funding for core and swing counties than for opposition counties. We build on this work by examining House earmark requests across all appropriations cycles in the post-moratorium era. By pairing geocoded data on FY2022–FY2026 House earmark requests with a regression discontinuity design, we are able to offer, to our knowledge, the first causal test of within-district co-partisan favoritism in U.S. House earmarks.

3 New Data on Congressional Earmarks

This section introduces the contemporary earmark regime and the new dataset we construct to study its within-district geography. We first explain how the post-moratorium rules—including limits on the number of requests and project-level disclosure—make earmark requests an unusually direct window into legislators’ distributive priorities. We then describe how we assemble the first comprehensive dataset of all Community Project Funding (CPF), i.e., “earmark,” requests submitted by U.S. House members between fiscal years 2022 and 2026, covering every year since Congress resumed earmarking after the ten-year moratorium. For each earmark project, our dataset records the requesting member, project description, recipient, requested dollar amount, subcommittee, policy area, and geocoded recipient location. These data provide the first systematic project-level account of the spatial allocation of contemporary House earmark requests. We conclude the section by documenting a series of descriptive patterns in earmark requests and allocations. Appendices A and B provide full details on the data collection process as well as additional descriptives for both requests and allocations.

3.1 Contemporary Earmarks Reveal Legislator Priorities

In their contemporary form, congressional earmarks offer an unusually direct window into how legislators prioritize constituencies within their district.⁸ After expanding substantially

⁸Earmarks are discretionary appropriations for specific projects or recipients that are awarded outside standard formula-based or competitive processes (Doyle, 2011; Fagan et al., 2023).

during the 1990s and 2000s, earmarks drew criticism for excessive spending and limited transparency. Congress responded with an initial series of disclosure reforms between 2006 and 2009 before imposing a moratorium beginning with the 112th Congress in 2011. When earmarks returned in 2021, they did so under a substantially revised institutional framework that makes legislators’ distributive choices far more transparent than under the old regime.

Under this contemporary earmarking regime, House earmarks must originate with local governments or eligible nonprofit organizations, which submit project proposals to their congressional representatives. Members then decide which proposals to formally request from the Appropriations Committee. Critically, the number of requests each House member may submit for consideration is capped, as is total earmark spending, requiring legislators to choose among competing projects rather than support every proposal they receive.⁹ The contemporary earmark process therefore reveals legislators’ priorities precisely because members cannot support every potential recipient or project.

New disclosure requirements accompanying the return of earmarks also make legislators’ spending priorities observable at an unusually fine geographic level. Appropriations committees are now required to release consolidated records of submitted requests, while individual members must disclose each project’s purpose, recipient, requested amount, and location on their official websites.¹⁰ Beginning with the FY2022 cycle, we can therefore observe the projects individual legislators choose to support before those requests are filtered through committee bargaining, negotiations between chambers, and the broader appropriations process.

A final advantage of studying congressional earmarks is their substantive breadth. House members may submit requests across the appropriations portfolio, including infrastructure, public safety, health, education, housing, environmental projects, and community development. Our analysis therefore does not depend on a single federal program or type of public good whose geographic distribution may be unusually well suited to targeting particular constituencies ([Kramon and Posner, 2013](#)).

Our analysis focuses primarily on members’ earmark requests, rather than allocated earmarked spending, because these requests most directly capture legislators’ spending priorities. In contrast, the final allocation of earmarked dollars reflects a combination of legislators’ priorities and the influence of downstream institutional actors. Final allocations, however, are what ultimately deliver material benefits to constituents. We therefore also collect and

⁹House members could submit up to 10 requests in FY2022, 15 in FY2023, and 20 in each fiscal year from FY2024 through FY2026. Total earmark allocations were capped at 1% of discretionary spending in FY2022 and FY2023 and 0.5% from FY2024 through FY2026 ([House Appropriations Committee, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025](#)).

¹⁰Earlier disclosure rules generally identified the requesting member only after an earmark was included in appropriations legislation.

analyze enacted spending. Examining both earmark requests and allocations allows us to isolate legislators’ distributive priorities before they are shaped by downstream bargaining and assess whether those priorities persist into enacted spending.

3.2 Construction of Earmarks Dataset

3.2.1 Earmark Requests

To study legislators’ targeting strategies, we construct the first systematic, project-level dataset of House members’ earmark requests since the resumption of earmarking in FY2022. We primarily construct this dataset from the consolidated CPF request tables that contemporary disclosure rules require the House Appropriations Committee to release for each fiscal year. Each row of these tables represents a single member request, recording the requesting member, subcommittee, project title or description, recipient, and requested dollar amount, along with, in most years, the member’s district and party, a disclosure-page link, and the recipient’s address. This dataset covers 23,510 CPF requests totaling \$85.38 billion between FY2022 and FY2026.

While the committees’ consolidated records provide most of the required information, project locations are missing for many requests in FY2022 and FY2023, the first two years under the new earmarking regime. To recover this information, we use an LLM-assisted retrieval, extraction, and matching procedure to collect members’ public disclosure materials from official websites and archived webpages, extract project-level locations, and match recovered records to the corresponding request from Committee records.¹¹ We then geolocate the projects in our database using the ArcGIS USA geocoder. Appendix A describes our data collection and geocoding procedures in detail.

Although each request is assigned to an appropriations subcommittee, subcommittee designations are often too coarse to capture the substantive purpose of individual projects.¹² For example, requests assigned to the “Transportation, Housing and Urban Development” subcommittee may support projects as varied as road improvements, public transit, affordable housing, airport facilities, and community development. To identify different policy priorities, we classify each project into one of eleven major policy areas using a large language model.¹³ To validate this classification, we independently hand-coded a random sample of

¹¹These steps use Anthropic’s Claude Opus 4.7.

¹²The relevant House appropriations subcommittees are: Agriculture, Rural Development, Food and Drug Administration, and Related Agencies; Commerce, Justice, Science, and Related Agencies; Defense; Energy and Water Development, and Related Agencies; Financial Services and General Government; Homeland Security; Interior, Environment, and Related Agencies; Labor, Health and Human Services, Education, and Related Agencies; Military Construction, Veterans Affairs, and Related Agencies; and Transportation, Housing and Urban Development, and Related Agencies.

¹³This step uses OpenAI’s GPT-5.5.

150 requests. Our human-coded labels agreed with the model’s on 88% of projects, corresponding to a Cohen’s κ of 0.86. Appendix A.3 describes this process in detail and visualizes the projects included in each category.

Finally, we merge our database with Voteview’s congressional membership records for the 117th, 118th, and 119th Congresses, which span our period of analysis.¹⁴ These records provide standardized identifiers and information on each member’s home state, congressional district, and party affiliation.

3.2.2 Earmark Allocations

While we primarily focus on earmark requests because they best capture legislator intent, we also collect final earmark allocations data, which allow us to observe whether each requested CPF project was included in that fiscal year’s enacted appropriations legislation and, if so, the amount appropriated.¹⁵ We collect these data from annual appropriations subcommittee reports available on the Senate Appropriations Committee’s website. These reports record each enacted project’s name or description, recipient, requesting member(s), state, appropriations account and agency, and appropriated amount. Using an LLM, we convert these reports into a standardized project-level dataset and match each enacted earmark to its corresponding record in our requests dataset.¹⁶ The resulting data preserve the full request-level records while adding measures of whether each project received funding and the amount ultimately allocated. Appendix B describes the full procedure in greater detail.

3.3 Characteristics of Earmark Requests

In this section, we describe the geographic coverage of earmark requests, their growth over time, partisan differences in requesting behavior, and the distribution of requests across policy areas.

Geographic Coverage Earmark requests achieve broad geographic reach. As Figure 1 shows, members of Congress in 48 of 50 states submitted earmark requests during our period of study.¹⁷ At the state level, the partisanship of the areas surrounding a state’s projects largely tracks the partisanship of the state as a whole: requests in heavily Democratic states

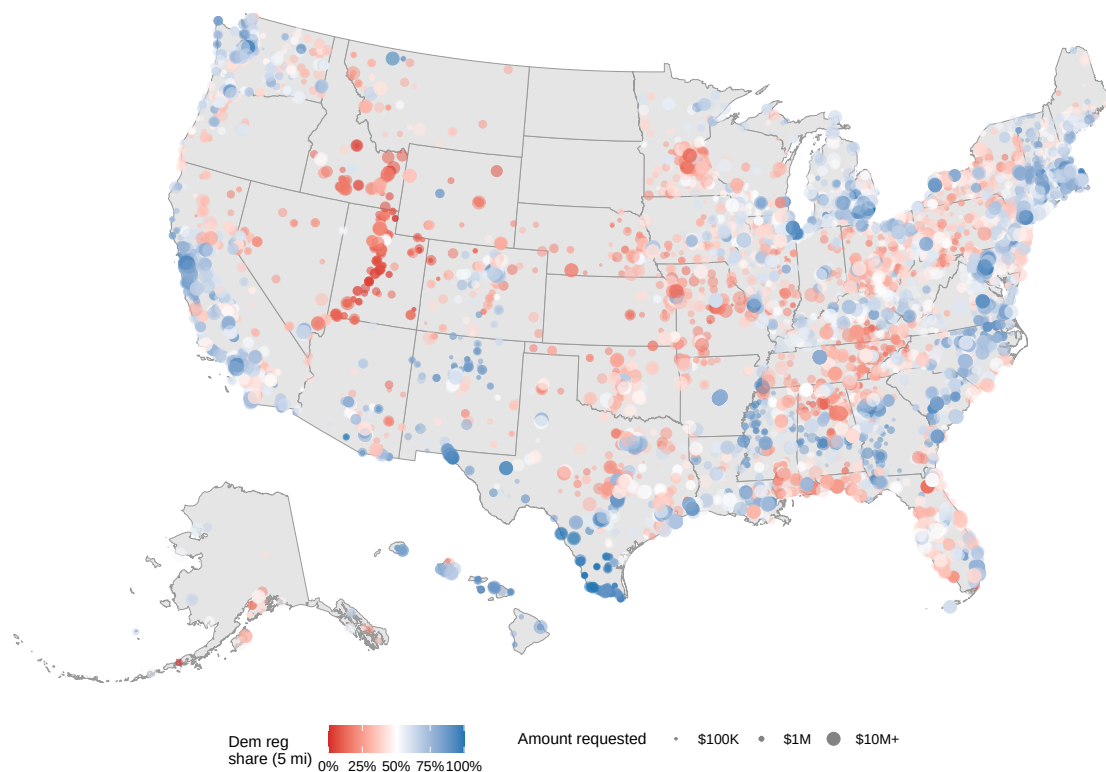
¹⁴The 117th Congress covers the FY2022 and FY2023 appropriations cycles, the 118th Congress the FY2024 and FY2025 cycles, and the 119th Congress the FY2026 and FY2027 cycles.

¹⁵Our allocation data measure the earmark amounts provided in enacted appropriations legislation rather than actual outlays, which we cannot observe at the project level.

¹⁶This step uses Anthropic’s Claude Opus 4.8.

¹⁷Republicans Kelly Armstrong of North Dakota and Dusty Johnson of South Dakota did not make any earmark requests between FY2022 and FY2026.

Figure 1 – Geographic Distribution of Earmark Requests, Colored by Democratic Registration Share Within 5 Miles. Each dot represents an individual earmark request. Appendix Figure C.1 presents this map disaggregated by fiscal year.

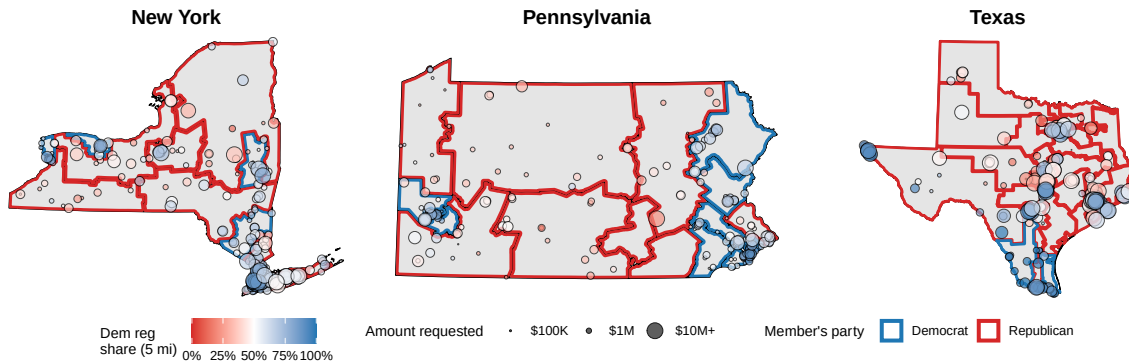


tend to fall near Democratic-leaning areas, and requests in heavily Republican states near Republican-leaning ones.¹⁸ Yet, this mechanical aggregate correlation masks substantial within-district variation in the partisan composition of areas near requested projects. Figure 2 illustrates this pattern in three states chosen to span the partisan spectrum: New York, which leans Democratic; Texas, which leans Republican; and Pennsylvania, whose congressional delegation is closely divided. In each state, districts represented by a single party nonetheless contain requests sited near neighborhoods of varying partisanship. Republican-held districts, for instance, include projects near strongly Democratic areas as well as strongly Republican ones (and vice versa for Democratic-held districts).

Growth Over Time Earmarking expanded rapidly on both the extensive and intensive margins during our period of study. As Figure 3 shows, the number of submitted projects rose from 3,041 in FY2022 to 5,414 in FY2026, and total requested funding more than tripled, from \$7.1 billion to \$23.4 billion. This pattern is driven by members submitting both more

¹⁸Appendix Figure C.1 shows that these patterns hold individually in each fiscal year, FY2022–FY2026.

Figure 2 – Earmark Requests in New York, Pennsylvania, and Texas, FY2024. Each dot is an individual FY2024 request, sized by its requested amount and shaded by the Democratic registration share within five miles of the project. Congressional districts are outlined by the requesting member’s party.

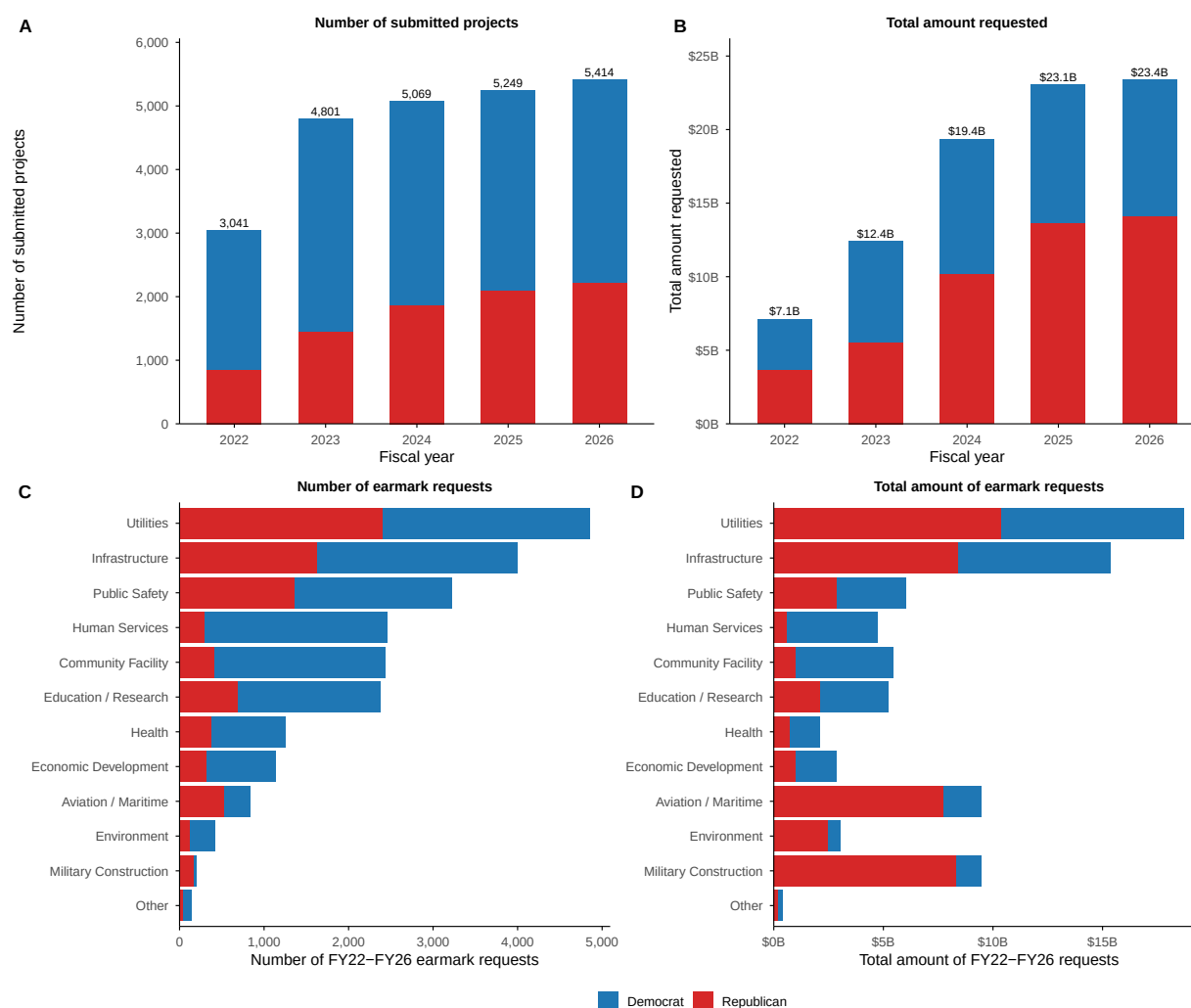


and larger requests over time. The average member submitted roughly 9 projects in FY2022 and about 14 in each subsequent year, while the median request grew from \$975,000 to \$2.1 million. The figure also shows that requested amounts are highly right-skewed, with a few infrastructure projects reaching hundreds of millions of dollars, while most remain below \$2 million.

Partisan Differences Figure 3 plots the intensive and extensive margins of Democratic and Republican earmark requests in aggregate and by policy area. Panels A and B show that Democrats tend to submit more projects, while Republicans request more money per project. Across our period of study, Democrats submitted 64% of all projects, but Republicans accounted for 55% of requested funding (\$47.0 billion). This gap is driven by partisan differences in average request size: while members face limits on the number of projects they can submit, there is no corresponding cap on the amount requested for each project. The average Republican request was \$5.6 million, more than twice the Democratic average of \$2.5 million.

Policy Areas Despite contentious debates over spending priorities, Democratic and Republican members of Congress appear to prioritize similar policy areas, on average, in their requested earmarks. Panels C and D of Figure 3 show that members of both parties concentrate their requests on utilities, infrastructure, and public safety, which collectively make up 59% of total projects and 50% of requested dollars. There are pronounced partisan dif-

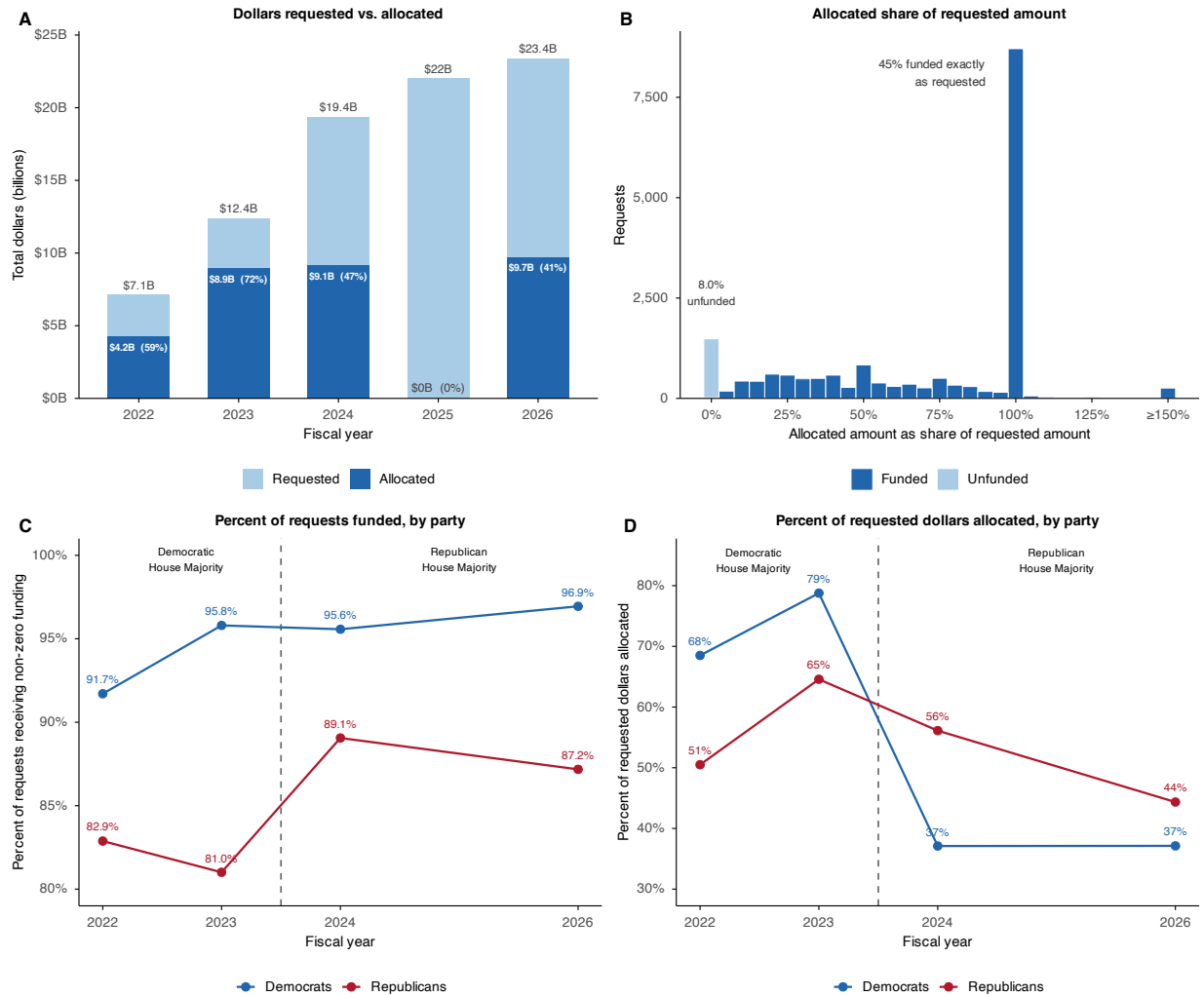
Figure 3 – Volume and Composition of House CPF Submissions. Panels A–B show, by fiscal year, the count of submitted CPF projects (A) and the total dollar amount requested (B). Panels C–D show the count (C) and total amount (D) requested in each policy category. Party for FY2022–FY2023 requests, which the source files omit, is assigned from Voteview’s 117th Congress roster. In every panel, bars are stacked by the submitting member’s party.



ferences, however, outside of these three largest categories. Democratic legislators account for the vast majority of projects for community facilities, human services, and education/research, while Republicans tend to disproportionately prioritize military construction and aviation/maritime projects.¹⁹

¹⁹Earmarks cannot fund direct military spending such as procurement, operations, personnel, or contracts to defense firms. Military earmarks are instead limited to construction of physical facilities on installations (e.g., National Guard readiness centers), funded through the Military Construction and Veterans Affairs subcommittee.

Figure 4 – Earmark Requests vs. Enacted Allocations. Panel A compares the total dollars House members requested to the dollars ultimately enacted in each fiscal year’s appropriations bills. FY2025 shows zero allocated dollars because it was funded through a full-year continuing resolution and no earmarks were enacted. Panel B shows each funded request’s allocated amount as a percent of the requested amount, pooling all fiscal years. Panel C plots the percent of each party’s requests receiving any funding, by fiscal year. Panel D plots the percent of each party’s requested dollars that were ultimately allocated. FY2025 is omitted from Panels B–D.



3.4 Characteristics of Earmark Allocations

Finally, in this subsection we compare which requested earmark projects survive the appropriations process and assess differences over time. Figure 4 compares legislators’ requested earmarks to the allocations ultimately included in each year’s appropriations bill.

Requests vs. Allocations Nearly all requested earmark projects are allocated funding, but often less than the amount requested. As Panel A of Figure 4 shows, the gap between requested and allocated dollars widens over time as total requested dollars have increased. In FY2022—the first year after the moratorium—Congress allocated approximately \$4.2 billion of the \$7.1 billion requested (59%). Allocations rise to roughly \$9–10 billion for the remainder of the period, even as requested dollars increased. Panel B plots each earmark’s allocated amount as a share of the requested amount. As the figure illustrates, the vast majority of requests received at least some funding, with only 8.0% of requests receiving zero funding. Nearly half (45%) of project requests were funded at exactly the requested amount and another 43% were funded at a lower amount, with haircuts spread fairly evenly across the distribution. In other words, rather than rejecting large numbers of requests outright, Congress typically funds projects but reduces their size.²⁰

Allocations by Majority Status Panel C of Figure 4 plots the percent of each party’s requests that received at least some funding, while Panel D reports the percent of each party’s requested dollars that were ultimately allocated. Panel C shows that Democratic requests were more likely than Republican requests to receive at least some funding in every fiscal year, a pattern that persists even after Republicans took control of the House in FY2024. Panel D, however, reveals a pronounced shift in the share of requested dollars ultimately allocated. Under Democratic control in FY2022–FY2023, 68–79% of Democratic-requested dollars were allocated; after Republicans assumed the majority, that share fell to 37%. Together, the two panels suggest that the majority party exercises its control over the appropriations process not by rejecting the minority party’s projects outright, but by cutting their size.

4 Empirical Design

We combine our geocoded earmarks dataset with voter registration records to examine whether legislators disproportionately direct requests toward co-partisan areas of their districts. In this section, we first describe how we measure the local partisan composition near each request before introducing our regression discontinuity (RD) design.

Measuring Local Partisan Composition We measure the partisan composition near each earmark request by combining our earmarks data with geocoded voter-file records from

²⁰Earmarks were not funded in FY2025, because Congress failed to pass an appropriations bill and instead operated through a series of continuing resolutions which explicitly excluded earmark funding.

the data vendor L2.²¹ L2 is a large commercial voter-data vendor, widely used in political science research, that standardizes official state registration files into a national database of registered voters and geocodes their residential addresses (Hersh, 2015; Fraga, 2018; Fos et al., 2022; Allcott et al., 2020). These data allow us to measure the partisan composition of registered voters surrounding each earmark request.

Our primary outcome is the dollar-weighted average Democratic registration share within an r -mile radius of a district’s earmark requests in each election cycle. Formally, let P_{dt} denote the set of earmark projects requested in district d and general-election cycle t . We define

$$Y_{dt}^r = \frac{\sum_{p \in P_{dt}} \text{Amount}_{pdt} \cdot \text{Dem Registration Share}_{pdt}^r}{\sum_{p \in P_{dt}} \text{Amount}_{pdt}}, \quad (1)$$

where p indexes an earmark project, Amount_{pdt} is the dollar amount requested for project p , and $\text{Dem Registration Share}_{pdt}^r$ is the two-party share of Democratic registrants within r miles of project p . To ensure this measure does not capture any downstream effects of earmarks on party registration, we use a voter-file snapshot from the year preceding the first cycle in our data to measure $\text{Dem Registration Share}_{pdt}^r$.

Our outcome therefore measures the Democratic registration share surrounding the average requested dollar, rather than the average project. We use a dollar-weighted outcome given our theoretical interest in the intensive margin of requested spending, rather than merely where projects are located. Whereas a project-weighted measure treats all requests equally regardless of size, Y_{dt}^r captures whether members direct larger requests disproportionately toward areas with different partisan compositions. Thus, even if a member submits the same number of projects in Democratic- and Republican-leaning areas, the outcome will reflect a partisan tilt when the requested dollar amounts in one set of areas are systematically larger.²² In Appendix G, we show that our substantive conclusions are unchanged when we weight each project equally.

This construction also distinguishes the within-district geography of requests from parti-

²¹In 33 states, L2’s partisan classification reflects voters’ self-declared party affiliation as recorded in the state’s official voter-registration file, or the party of the most recent primary in which they participated. In the remaining 17 states, L2 imputes partisan classification using a proprietary model trained on primary-ballot choice and demographic data. In Appendix F, we show that our headline estimates are slightly larger when we restrict our sample to the 33 states whose registration files record party affiliation (8.7 versus 7.5 percentage points). Appendix F also shows that our substantive conclusions are unchanged when we instead measure neighborhood partisanship using geocoded precinct-level presidential vote share.

²²This outcome also maps closely onto probabilistic voting models of distributive politics which motivate this study (Cox and McCubbins, 1986; Lindbeck and Weibull, 1987; Dixit and Londregan, 1996). In these models, politicians allocate a divisible pool of resources across groups, directing a larger share toward groups for which spending is expected to produce greater electoral returns. Our dollar-weighted outcome captures an analogous empirical quantity: whether larger shares of requested spending are directed toward areas with particular partisan compositions.

san differences in overall earmark activity. Thus, the fact that Republican members submit fewer requests, or that Democratic members request fewer total dollars (as illustrated in Section 3.3), does not mechanically generate a partisan difference in our outcome among district-cycles. Because Y_{dt}^r is normalized by total requested dollars, a proportional increase in requested amounts across all locations leaves it unchanged. The outcome changes only when the relative allocation of requested dollars shifts toward areas with different partisan compositions. Thus, Y_{dt}^r captures partisan differences in how requested dollars are targeted within districts.

Regression Discontinuity Design To identify whether legislators disproportionately funnel earmark requests to co-partisan areas, we adopt a regression discontinuity design in U.S. House general elections (Lee, 2008). The design compares the distribution of earmark requests across districts that narrowly elect a Democratic versus a Republican legislator. Specifically, we estimate equations of the form

$$Y_{dt}^r = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Dem Win}_{dt} + f(\text{Dem Win Margin}_{dt}) + \varepsilon_{dt}, \quad (2)$$

where Dem Win_{dt} indicates that the Democratic candidate won district d 's election in cycle t , and $f(\cdot)$ is a flexible function of the Democratic candidate's win margin. We assign each request to the election cycle corresponding to the term of the member who submitted it. The outcome Y_{dt}^r measures the partisan composition of voters within an r -mile buffer of the district's requests, as defined in Equation 1.

The key parameter of interest, β_1 , captures the causal effect of electing a Democratic legislator on the spatial composition of earmark requests in 50–50 elections, relative to a Republican. Although closely contested races represent a narrow slice of U.S. House elections, they are substantively important cases for studying distributive targeting because electoral incentives to strategically allocate resources are especially strong when electoral margins are narrow. In Section 6.2.2, we complement the RD with a panel-based identification strategy and show that our results generalize beyond the set of close, contested elections that underlie our main RD design.

Identification The identifying assumption that underlies this design is that parties' potential earmark requests are continuous near the victory cutoff (Imbens and Lemieux, 2008; Lee and Lemieux, 2010). As Eggers et al. (2015) note, this assumption is highly plausible, because candidates in close elections rarely have access to polling that is precise enough to identify their location relative to the discontinuity. In Appendix E, we supplement this evidence with a local-polynomial density-discontinuity test developed by Cattaneo et al. (2020)

and find no evidence of sorting around the cutoff.

The central advantage of this design is that it distinguishes the effect of representative party from pre-existing differences in where viable earmark projects are located. Without this design, Democratic legislators might appear to favor co-partisans simply because fundable projects in their districts are concentrated in Democratic areas, while Republican legislators might appear to do the same because viable projects in their districts are concentrated in Republican areas. Near the close-election threshold, however, the underlying geography of project opportunities varies smoothly, while the party of the elected representative changes discontinuously, allowing us to identify how representative party shapes the geography of earmark requests.

This design does not, by itself, distinguish all mechanisms that could generate a non-zero point estimate. While the RD provides balance on the pre-treatment geography of earmark opportunities, it does not balance the type of projects Democratic and Republican legislators request. If, for example, Democratic legislators prioritize health, education, and public transit projects, and those projects are disproportionately located in Democratic-leaning areas, Democratic representation could shift earmark requests toward Democratic neighborhoods even absent direct partisan targeting.²³ To probe this possibility, in Section 6.1 we re-estimate our central RD design separately within each policy area to assess whether co-partisan favoritism persists within each policy area. Alternatively, partisan favoritism may arise if legislators target demographic groups that are themselves correlated with partisanship.²⁴ To evaluate this mechanism, in Section 6.2, we replace our main outcome with other characteristics of the population surrounding each earmark request, including racial composition, population density, poverty share, and educational attainment. These analyses allow us to assess whether co-partisan targeting exceeds targeting on the basis of other electorally salient constituencies that are correlated with partisanship.

5 Partisan Favoritism in Congressional Earmarks

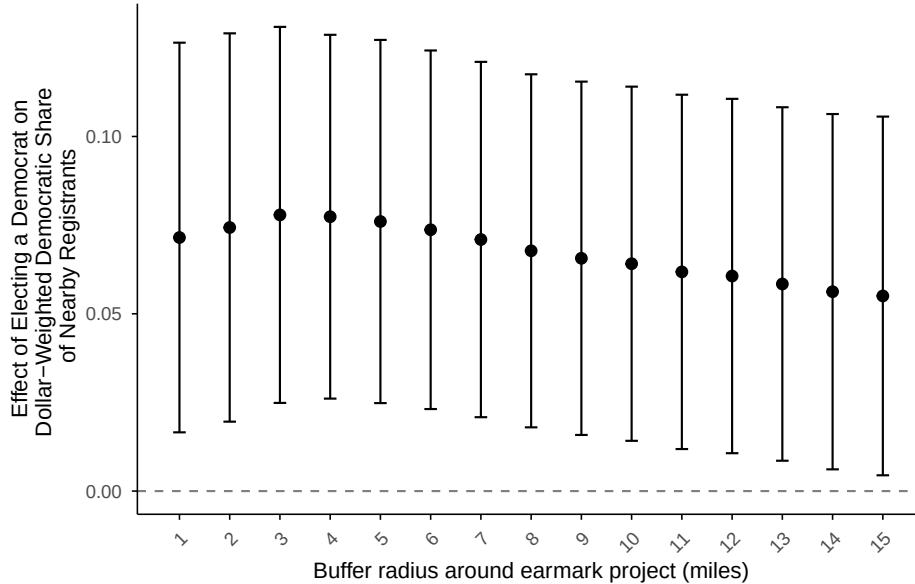
5.1 Legislators Target Co-Partisan Voters

Do members of Congress target co-partisan voters in their earmark requests? Figure 5 plots our estimates of β_1 from Equation 2 using the method from [Calonico et al. \(2014\)](#) to answer

²³Similarly, Republican legislators may prioritize categories such as rural infrastructure, water systems, or public safety projects that are disproportionately located in Republican-leaning areas.

²⁴For example, Democratic legislators may target non-white, urban, or highly educated communities, which are also more likely to be Democratic-leaning.

Figure 5 – Effect of Electing a Democrat on Democratic Share of Registrants Near Earmark Requests. The narrow election of a Democratic member of Congress increases the dollar-weighted two-party Democratic share of registered voters in the vicinity of earmark requests by 6 to 8 percentage points relative to electing a Republican. The horizontal axis reports the radius of voters included around each project.



this question.²⁵ The vertical axis in Figure 5 reports the effect of a narrow Democratic win on the dollar-weighted Democratic registration share, Y_{dt}^r , while the horizontal axis varies the project radius, r .

We find clear evidence of partisan favoritism. At every buffer radius from 1 to 15 miles, the estimated effect of a narrow Democratic win on co-partisan earmark requests is positive and statistically distinguishable from zero. Focusing on the estimate using a 5-mile radius, we find that narrowly electing a Democratic member of Congress increases the Democratic registration share surrounding the average earmark dollar by 8 percentage points relative to a narrow Republican victory. The estimates are largest at smaller radii, declining from 9 percentage points at 1 mile to 6 percentage points at 15 miles. This gradient is consistent with within-district targeting, since smaller buffers isolate co-partisan voters most sharply while larger ones average over a more heterogeneous population.

As is standard in RD analyses, Table 1 evaluates the robustness of our results across a variety of bandwidths and functional forms. For simplicity, we focus on the 5-mile radius specification. The first column in Table 1 replicates the 5-mile CCT estimate from Figure 5, with the corresponding RD plot shown in Appendix Figure D.1. In the second column,

²⁵This method uses kernel regression with a triangular kernel and a bandwidth that minimizes mean squared error. We implement the method using the R package *rdrobust*.

Table 1 – Effect of Electing a Democrat on Democratic Share of Registrants Near Earmark Requests, 5-Mile Radius. The narrow election of a Democratic member of Congress increases the dollar-weighted two-party Democratic share of registered voters within 5 miles of earmark requests by 4 to 8 percentage points relative to electing a Republican.

	Dollar-Weighted Democratic Registration Share			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Democratic Win	0.08 (0.03)	0.05 (0.02)	0.05 (0.02)	0.04 (0.02)
N	262	356	993	993
Specification	CCT	Linear	Cubic	IW
Spline	-	Yes	Yes	-
Bandwidth	0.07	0.10	-	-

Note: District-regime-clustered robust standard errors are reported in parentheses in columns (1)–(3). IW does not support clustered inference; its parenthesized value is the 95% confidence-interval half-length divided by 1.96. The running variable is the Democratic candidate’s general-election margin of victory. Spline indicates that the regression function was fit separately on either side of zero. Cubic refers to a third-order polynomial regression. CCT refers to the method from Calonico, Cattaneo, and Titiunik (2014). IW refers to the method from Imbens and Wager (2019).

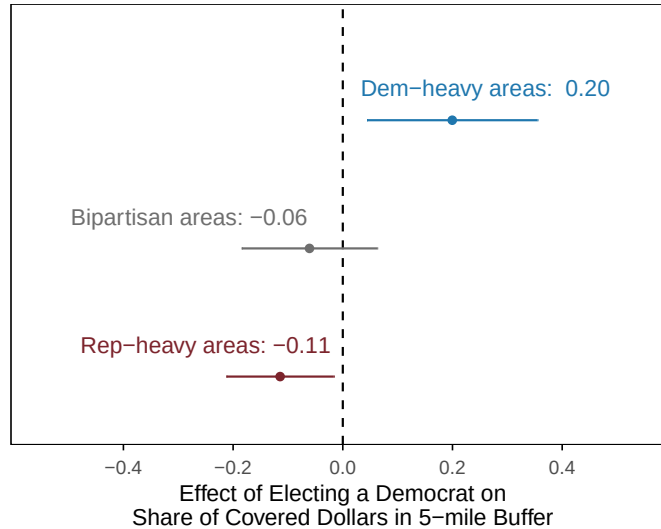
we use a local-linear specification of the running variable, $Dem\ Win\ Margin_{dt}$, and a 10% bandwidth fit separately on either side of the discontinuity (i.e., a spline). The third column fits a third-order polynomial using all available data and a spline. Finally, column four reports the estimate from Imbens and Wager’s (2019) *optrdd* R package, which uses convex optimization to construct the finite-sample minimax linear estimator of the discontinuity, given a bound on the curvature of the conditional expectation function.²⁶ Across all four specifications, we find precise evidence that legislators disproportionately funnel earmark requests to areas with more co-partisan voters.

5.2 Targeting Operates by Defunding Out-Party Strongholds

The results so far show that legislators direct earmark requests toward areas with more co-partisan voters, but they do not reveal the corresponding pattern of reallocation within the district. Do legislators shift dollars away from bipartisan areas, where both in- and out-party voters are present, or away from solidly out-partisan areas?

²⁶Following Imbens and Wager (2019), we obtain a conservative estimate of the second derivative of the conditional expectation function, B , using a global quadratic regression and multiplying the estimate by 2.

Figure 6 – Effect of Electing a Democrat on the Share of Project Dollars Placed in Each Neighborhood Type, 5-Mile Radius. Robust bias-corrected RDD estimates (Calonico et al., 2014) of the effect of a narrow Democratic win on the district-year share of earmark project dollars whose 5-mile buffer falls in each partisan bucket: Dem-heavy ($> 60\%$ Dem registration), bipartisan ($40\text{--}60\%$), or Rep-heavy ($< 40\%$). 95% robust confidence intervals shown. The narrow election of a Democratic member of Congress increases the share of earmark dollars requested in Democratic-heavy areas by 20 percentage points, while decreasing the share in Republican-heavy areas by 11 percentage points; the smaller drop in bipartisan areas (6 percentage points) is not statistically distinguishable from zero.



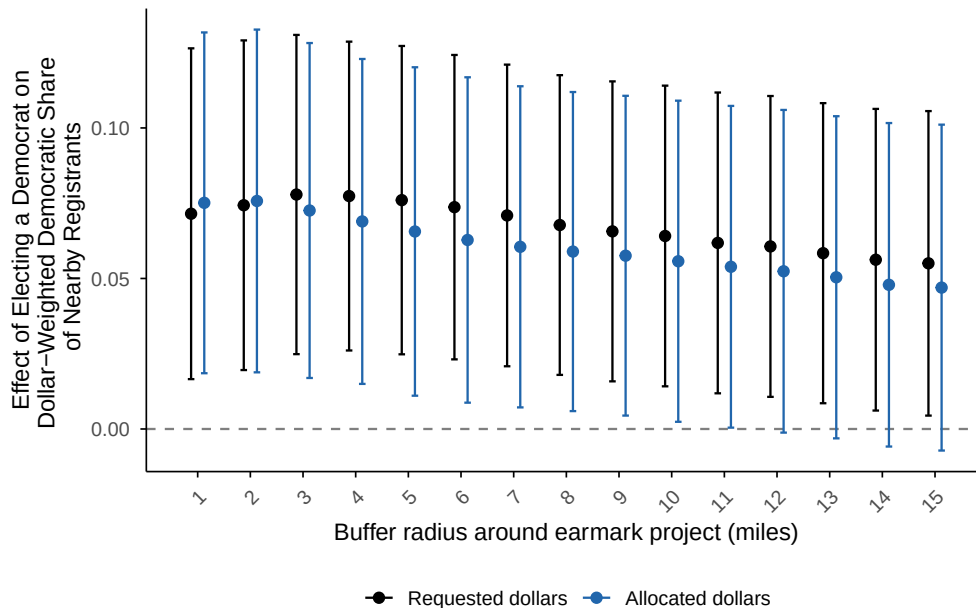
To answer this question, we classify each request into one of three mutually exclusive neighborhood types by local partisan composition: Dem-heavy ($> 60\%$ Democratic registration), bipartisan ($40\text{--}60\%$, endpoints included), and Rep-heavy ($< 40\%$). We then re-estimate our RD design separately for each neighborhood, using the share of a legislator’s earmark dollars flowing to a given neighborhood type.²⁷

Figure 6 reports the results. The first row shows that a narrow Democratic win raises the share of a legislator’s requested earmark dollars flowing to Democratic-heavy areas by 20 percentage points. The second and third rows show that this increase is offset primarily by reductions in Republican strongholds, where narrowly electing a Democrat lowers the share of earmark dollars by 11 percentage points, and to a lesser extent, by reducing requested dollars to bipartisan areas. In other words, the co-partisan favoritism we identify in Figure 5 operates primarily by shifting requested resources away from out-party neighborhoods.

The magnitude of the effects we identify is economically meaningful. In our data, the average request is \$2.5 million and the average legislator submits roughly 30 requests per

²⁷Formally, we define $Z_{dt}^N = \frac{\sum_{p \in N} \text{Amount}_{pdt}}{\sum_{p \in P_{dt}} \text{Amount}_{pdt}}$, where N is the subset of P_{dt} situated in a given neighborhood type. The three shares therefore sum to one in every district-cycle.

Figure 7 – Effect of Electing a Democrat on the Democratic Share of Registrants Near Requested vs. Allocated Earmarks. Black points replicate the headline estimates from Figure 5, in which each project is weighted by its requested dollars. Blue points re-estimate the same RD using only funded projects, weighting each by its enacted allocation; FY2025 requests, which were never fundable, drop out of the allocated series along with unfunded requests. 95% robust confidence intervals shown.



election cycle, for a portfolio of about \$75 million.²⁸ The first row in Figure 6 indicates that a narrowly elected legislator funnels an additional 20 percentage points of requested funds to co-partisan areas. This means that, on average, the narrow election of a Democrat leads to approximately \$14.8 million in requests redirected from bipartisan and Republican-heavy areas to Democratic strongholds. In Appendix Figure G.2, we show that this effect translates into roughly 3 additional projects in Democratic-heavy areas.

5.3 Partisan Favoritism Persists in Allocated Earmarks

Although requests reveal legislators’ initial distributive priorities, final allocations pass through committee review, inter-chamber bargaining, and project-level adjustments that could attenuate or eliminate the partisan geography of those requests. Does the partisan favoritism we document in earmark requests survive the appropriations process?

To answer this question, we re-estimate Equation 2 using only funded projects, weighting

²⁸The number of requests and total earmark spending change across fiscal years. Total earmark allocations were capped at 1% of discretionary spending for FY2022–FY2023 and 0.5% for FY2024–FY2027, and House members could submit 10 requests in FY2022, 15 in FY2023, and 20 in each of FY2024–FY2027.

each project by its allocated rather than requested amount when constructing the outcome in Equation 1. The blue points in Figure 7 plot these allocation-based estimates, while the black points reproduce the request-based estimates from Figure 5. We find that partisan favoritism persists in allocated earmarks. As the figure shows, our point estimates are highly similar across all project radii. At the 5-mile radius, electing a Democrat increases the allocation-weighted Democratic registration share near funded projects by 6.7 percentage points ($p = 0.02$), similar to the 8-percentage-point effect for requested dollars. These results show that the appropriations process does not eliminate the co-partisan favoritism displayed in legislators' initial requests. The patterns we identify extend to enacted spending, materially affecting the distribution of public resources across the country and within districts.

6 Mechanisms

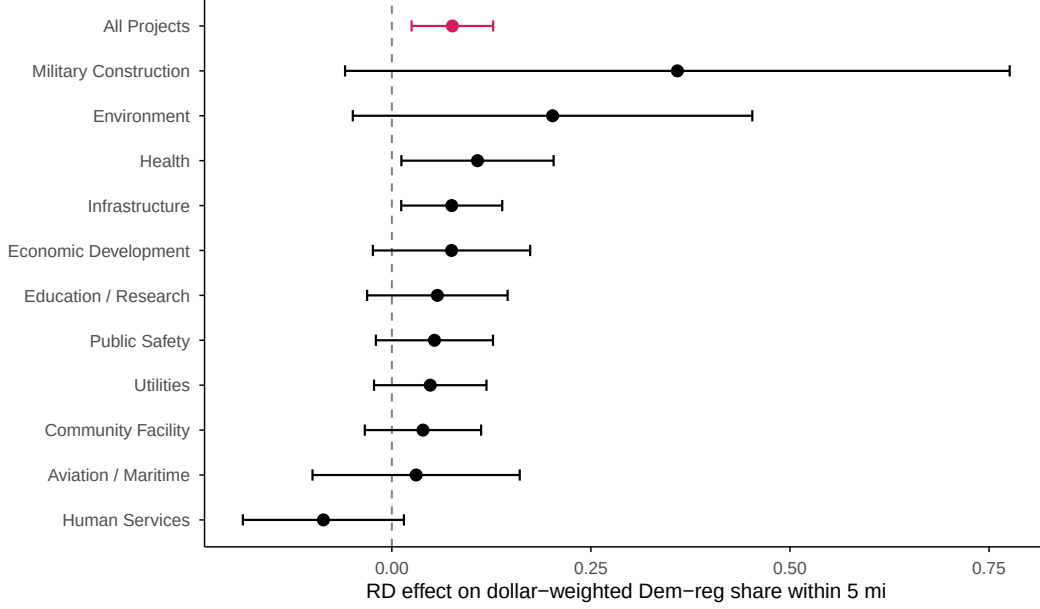
Our main results establish that legislators disproportionately direct earmark spending toward co-partisan areas. In this section, we consider three mechanisms that could drive this partisan favoritism. First, partisan favoritism may arise from partisan differences in policy priorities: Democratic and Republican legislators may prioritize different types of projects that are themselves located in neighborhoods with different partisan compositions. We find that co-partisan favoritism persists within narrowly defined policy areas, suggesting that the headline effects do not primarily operate through partisan differences in policy priorities. Second, we examine whether these patterns are driven by legislators targeting on the basis of socio-demographic characteristics, such as race, population density, education, or economic need, which are themselves spatially correlated with partisanship. We find that partisan targeting exceeds targeting on these socio-demographic dimensions, suggesting that partisanship is a distinct basis of distributive targeting.

Finally, we study whether partisan favoritism reflects electoral incentives. Drawing on classic theories of distributive politics, we assess whether legislators direct resources toward core or swing voters within their co-partisan base (Cox and McCubbins, 1986; Lindbeck and Weibull, 1987; Dixit and Londregan, 1996). Using individual campaign donors as a proxy for legislators' most committed supporters, we find no evidence that legislators disproportionately target these core co-partisans. The results are instead more consistent with legislators directing earmarks toward swing co-partisans rather than rewarding their partisan core.

6.1 Co-Partisan Targeting Persists Across Policy Areas

We first assess whether the patterns we observe are driven by differences in the policy areas that legislators prioritize. Democratic and Republican legislators may request different types

Figure 8 – Effect of Electing a Democrat on the Democratic Share of Registrants Within 5 Miles by Project Policy Area. The narrow election of a Democratic member of Congress increases the dollar-weighted two-party Democratic share of registered voters within 5 miles of earmark requests, even within policy areas.



of projects, and those project types may be located in neighborhoods with different partisan compositions. For example, Democratic legislators may prioritize health, education, or transit projects that are disproportionately located in Democratic-leaning areas, while Republican legislators may prioritize project types more common in Republican-leaning areas.²⁹ If so, the partisan geography of earmark requests would reflect partisan differences in policy priorities.

To probe this possibility, we re-estimate Equation 2 separately within each of the eleven policy categories introduced in Section 3. Hence, our outcome becomes

$$Y_{dt}^{cr} = \frac{\sum_{p \in C_{dt}} Amount_{pdt} \cdot Dem\ Registration\ Share_{pdt}^r}{\sum_{p \in C_{dt}} Amount_{pdt}}, \quad (3)$$

where C_{dt} represents the set of projects in a given policy category, c .

Figure 8 plots our estimates of policy-specific earmark distribution using a 5-mile project radius and the estimator from [Calonico et al. \(2014\)](#). As the figure shows, we find evidence of co-partisan targeting in ten of eleven policy areas. Across these categories, the estimated shift in the dollar-weighted Democratic registration share ranges from roughly 3 to 36 per-

²⁹Partisan differences in policy priorities are a well-documented pattern in American politics ([Petrocik, 1996](#); [Egan, 2013](#)).

centage points, with the largest effects in military construction and environment and the most precisely estimated effects in health and infrastructure. Co-partisan targeting therefore persists among substantively similar projects, suggesting that partisan favoritism does not operate primarily through differences in the policy areas legislators prioritize.³⁰

6.2 Co-Partisan Targeting Exceeds Socio-Demographic Targeting

We now examine whether our main results are driven by legislators targeting constituents on the basis of socio-demographic characteristics that are themselves spatially correlated with partisanship. To assess this possibility, we benchmark co-partisan targeting against socio-demographic targeting using two complementary research designs. First, we focus on four socio-demographic characteristics—race, population density, educational attainment, and poverty—which, as shown in Appendix I, are correlated with Democratic registration. We then complement our RD approach with a grid cell analysis that absorbs time-invariant features of each cell, including other unobserved characteristics that may shape earmark requests. This design allows us to assess whether changes in requested earmark dollars track a neighborhood’s partisanship or its socio-demographic profile when partisan representation changes, while also extending the analysis beyond the close elections that underlie the RD.

6.2.1 Alternative Regression Discontinuity Outcomes

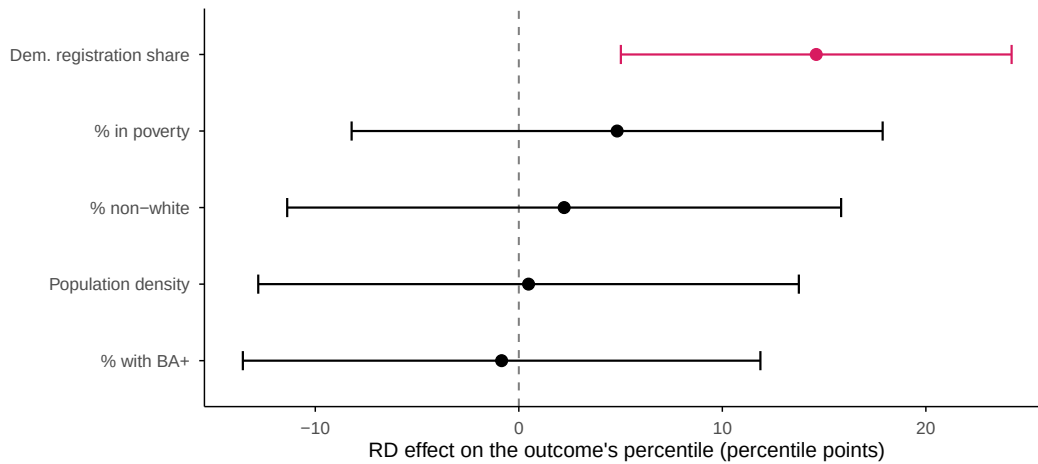
We begin by using our regression discontinuity design to evaluate the extent to which the parties differentially target individual socio-demographic groups. To do so, we re-estimate Equation 2, replacing the Democratic registration share in our dollar-weighted outcome, $Dem\ Registration\ Share_{pdt}^r$, with each of four socio-demographic outcomes: the share of non-white residents, population density, the share of residents with a bachelor’s degree or higher, and the share of residents below the poverty line, each measured within a 5-mile radius of requested projects.³¹ Because these outcomes are measured on different scales, we make the RD estimates comparable by converting each outcome to its sample percentile before estimation. Each effect is therefore expressed in percentile points, which indicate how far electing a Democrat moves the targeted area up the distribution of that characteristic.

Figure 9 reports the results. The first row shows that electing a Democrat moves the

³⁰Some types of projects may be more geographically constrained than others. For example, Military Construction requests are likely limited by existing military installations. In Appendix Figure H.2 we show that our central estimate in Figure 5 remains highly similar after excluding requests directed to each appropriations subcommittee in turn.

³¹Since state voter files do not consistently report race, educational attainment, or income, we impute these variables using block-group-level data from the Census Bureau. Our point estimates are highly similar, however, when using the modeled education and race variables provided by L2.

Figure 9 – Effect of Electing a Democrat on Earmark Targeting by Party, Race, Population Density, Education, and Economic Need, 5-Mile Radius. Each point is the regression-discontinuity effect on the targeted area’s percentile in the given outcome’s distribution (percentile points), a common scale robust to differences in scale and skew across outcomes. Electing a Democrat significantly increases targeting on the basis of party, whereas the demographic and economic-need placebos—race, population density, education, and poverty—are not individually distinguishable from zero.



targeted area roughly 15 percentiles up the Democratic-registration distribution, a large and statistically significant shift.³² By contrast, the corresponding effects on race, population density, education, and poverty are all small and statistically indistinguishable from zero. In other words, co-partisan favoritism is not driven by legislators directing resources toward other socio-demographic groups that are correlated with party.

The analysis in Figure 9 estimates targeting along each socio-demographic dimension separately, which allows us to directly compare the strength of targeting on the basis of partisanship with other correlated characteristics. Legislators may, however, target areas based on a combination of these characteristics. To account for this, we residualize the Democratic registration share within 5 miles of each earmark request with respect to the four socio-demographic covariates in Figure 9 and reconstruct the dollar-weighted outcome in Equation 1 using the residualized measure. This approach asks whether legislators disproportionately direct earmark requests towards co-partisan areas after removing the portion of local partisanship that is related to our socio-demographic covariates. As we show in Appendix I, co-partisan favoritism persists after accounting for the covariates jointly.

³²The raw point estimates underlying the figure, in each outcome’s native units, are reported in Appendix Table I.1 and show the same substantive conclusion.

6.2.2 Grid Cell Analysis

The preceding analyses suggest that co-partisan favoritism is not simply a by-product of legislators targeting observed socio-demographic groups that are correlated with party. Because any covariate-based test is limited to the characteristics we can measure, we complement our RD approach using a grid cell analysis. Rather than asking whether Democratic and Republican legislators target different kinds of places in the cross-section, this design asks whether a cell receives more or fewer requested earmarks across fiscal years when the party representing it changes. By including grid cell fixed effects, the design therefore accounts for time-invariant baseline features of each area that may shape earmark opportunities, including administrative capacity, local need, project availability, and other unmeasured characteristics. This approach also allows us to compare partisan and socio-demographic targeting beyond the small subset of districts featuring close, contested elections that underlie our main RD design.

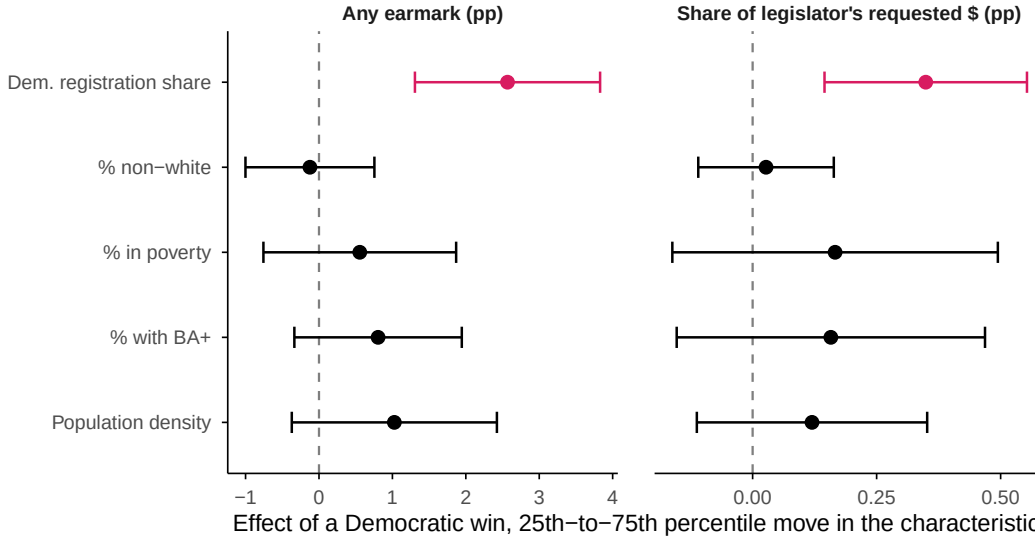
Specifically, we conduct the analysis using 5×5 mile grid cells, where each cell is assigned in each congressional term to the district containing its centroid. We measure each cell’s partisan composition using the voter-file data and impute demographic characteristics from Census block groups using areal interpolation. The resulting grid cell panel contains 53,104 cells observed over five fiscal years,³³ 9.5% of which receive a requested earmark at some point between FY2022 and FY2026. Appendix J reports additional details on the construction of the grid cell panel.

Our design compares changes in earmarks requested for each grid cell across fiscal years when the party representing it changes. We leverage two sources of variation in party representation: electoral turnover, when a district switches parties, and the 2022 decennial redistricting process, which reassigned some areas from Democratic to Republican representation or vice versa. The analysis asks whether cells are more likely to receive earmarks when representation shifts toward the party that matches the majority of registrants, and whether those gains track the cell’s partisan composition or its demographic profile, once each is conditioned on the other. To implement this design, we estimate the following two-way fixed effects specification

$$Y_{it} = \alpha_i + \delta_t + \beta \text{Dem Win}_{dt} + \gamma \text{Dem Win}_{dt} \times \text{Dem Registration Share}_i + \sum_{k=1}^4 \theta_k \text{Dem Win}_{dt} \times X_{ik} + \varepsilon_{it}, \quad (4)$$

³³The full gridded panel contains 144,057 distinct cells, but many are sparsely populated. We retain only cells with at least 25 registered Democrats or Republicans, which comprise 45.6% of all cells. Our retained sample covers 99.7% of all cell-assigned earmark dollars and 99.2% of cells that ever receive an earmark.

Figure 10 – Effect of Electing a Democrat on Within-District Earmark Targeting by Party Registration, Race, Economic Need, Education, and Population Density, 5-Mile Grid Cells. Each point is the interaction between a Democratic win and one fixed characteristic of a grid cell, reported for a move from the 25th to the 75th percentile of that characteristic, from a regression with grid cell and fiscal year fixed effects that compares cells whose representation changes over FY2022–FY2026. Standard errors clustered by district election.



where i indexes grid cells, t indexes fiscal years, and d denotes the district containing cell i in year t . $Dem\ Registration\ Share_i$ is the cell's two-party Democratic registration share. The characteristics X_{ik} include the same demographic covariates from Section 6.2.1: the cell's non-white share, poverty rate, share of residents holding a bachelor's degree or higher, and population density. Grid cell fixed effects, α_i , absorb time-invariant differences across cells, while fiscal year fixed effects, δ_t , absorb annual common shocks. We consider two outcomes: an indicator for whether the cell receives any earmark request in a given year and the cell's share of the legislator's requested earmark dollars.

The coefficient β captures the average difference in earmark activity under Democratic representation across all cells. The interaction coefficient γ captures whether more Democratic cells receive a larger relative gain under Democratic representation, conditional on the socio-demographic characteristics in X_{ik} . Similarly, θ_k measures whether cells with higher values of characteristic k receive larger gains under Democratic representation, holding Democratic registration share and the remaining characteristics constant.

Figure 10 reports the results from this analysis. The first row plots our estimate of γ , while subsequent rows plot θ_k . Since our covariates are on different scales, we follow the same approach as in Figure 9 and convert each characteristic to its percentile in the sample

distribution before estimation. Each plotted coefficient captures the change in earmark activity when a cell moves from the 25th to the 75th percentile of the characteristic under Democratic relative to Republican representation.

The left panel of Figure 10 uses the probability of receiving an earmark request in a given fiscal year as the outcome variable. In our estimation sample, 4.84% of cell-years receive a request. The first row shows that moving from the 25th to the 75th percentile of Democratic registration share increases the probability of receiving an earmark under Democratic representation by an additional 2.3 percentage points relative to Republican representation, or roughly half the base rate. The remaining rows report analogous estimates for the socio-demographic covariates. With the exception of share non-white, the point estimates are positive, consistent with Democratic legislators requesting earmarks in denser, poorer, and more educated areas. None of these estimates, however, is statistically distinguishable from zero at conventional levels, and each is substantially smaller than the corresponding estimate for Democratic registration share.

The right panel of Figure 10 then turns to the intensive margin, or the share of a legislator’s requested earmark dollars directed to a given cell. Because each legislator’s requested dollars are divided across many cells, the average cell accounts for just 0.80% of a district’s requested earmark funding. Against this baseline, moving from the 25th to the 75th percentile of Democratic registration share increases a cell’s share of the legislator’s requested dollars under Democratic representation by 0.29 percentage points—roughly one-third of the average cell share—while none of the other socio-demographic characteristics approaches statistical significance.

Overall, the grid cell results reinforce the conclusions from the RD analyses while extending them beyond close, contested elections. Across both designs, co-partisan favoritism does not appear to be simply driven by legislators targeting socio-demographic constituencies that are correlated with party. Electing a Democrat does not meaningfully shift requested dollars toward more non-white, denser, poorer, or more educated areas. And when partisan and socio-demographic characteristics are jointly estimated, only partisan composition predicts greater earmark dollars when representation changes hands. In other words, these results suggest that partisanship is a distinct basis of distributive targeting.

6.3 Legislators Do Not Target Core Co-Partisan Supporters

Finally, we relate our results to classic theories of distributive politics, which offer competing predictions about which groups politicians should target with distributive spending (Cox and McCubbins, 1986; Lindbeck and Weibull, 1987; Dixit and Londregan, 1996). However, these theories do not map cleanly onto the differential targeting patterns identified by our empirical

design. We therefore develop their implications for the contemporary U.S. context and then provide additional analyses to adjudicate between them.

We begin by clarifying the theoretical predictions of each theory. The swing-voter model of [Lindbeck and Weibull \(1987\)](#) argues that politicians target distributive spending toward groups whose votes are most responsive to such benefits—that is, where votes are cheapest to acquire. In the contemporary U.S. context, this symmetric model implies that Democratic and Republican legislators should both target the same electorally marginal or persuadable voters. [Cox and McCubbins \(1986\)](#), by contrast, argue that vote-maximizing politicians target core supporters in order to shore up electoral support among their partisan base. Finally, [Dixit and Londregan \(1996\)](#) develop a more general model that incorporates incentives for both swing-voter and core-voter targeting. In their framework, optimal targeting depends in part on politicians’ ability to deliver benefits effectively, which may itself be correlated with voters’ partisan affinity.

Our results are difficult to reconcile with a symmetric swing-voter targeting model. If Democratic and Republican legislators have incentives to target the same electorally responsive constituencies, then changing the partisan identity of the winning candidate should not systematically alter the partisan composition of targeted areas. The [Lindbeck and Weibull \(1987\)](#) model therefore suggests a null RD estimate in our empirical setting. Instead, we find that narrow Democratic and Republican victories produce systematically different allocation patterns across partisan constituencies. This divergence is inconsistent with a symmetric model of swing-voter targeting.

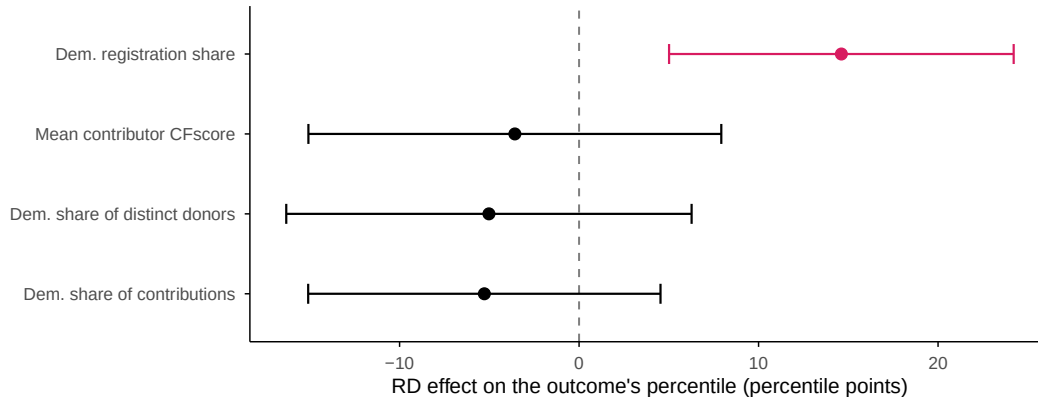
At the same time, our results do not necessarily imply that legislators do not target electorally responsive voters. In the contemporary U.S. electorate, electoral responsiveness and partisan affinity need not be independent: voters most responsive to distributive benefits may themselves be aligned with the legislator’s party. In an increasingly partisan electorate, distributive spending may therefore be most effective at mobilizing or retaining marginal co-partisans.³⁴ Our results establish that co-partisan representation shifts spending toward co-partisan constituencies, but they do not reveal whether legislators target these areas because they contain more core or swing co-partisans.³⁵

To adjudicate between core- and swing-voter targeting, we use individual campaign donors as a proxy for core supporters. Individual donors are a natural proxy for a party’s core supporters, because they are widely understood to be more attached to their party than non-donors, including primary voters ([Hill and Huber, 2017](#); [Broockman and Malhotra, 2020](#)).

³⁴As ticket splitting has become increasingly rare ([Jacobson, 2015](#)), electorally marginal voters may be more likely to vary in whether they turn out than in which party they support.

³⁵This is related to the empirical challenge of differentiating groups from areas. See the discussion on pages 346–347 in [Cox \(2009\)](#).

Figure 11 – Effect of Electing a Democrat on the Concentration of Core Co-Partisan Donors Near Earmark Requests, 5-Mile Radius. Each point is the regression-discontinuity effect of a narrow Democratic win on a dollar-weighted district-year outcome measured within five miles of requested projects. In the first row, the outcome is the Democratic registration share. The remaining rows use individual contributors to either major-party candidate in the member’s own House race. Each outcome is converted to its sample percentile before estimation, so all effects are in percentile points as in Figure 9. 95% robust confidence intervals shown.



We re-estimate our main RD design using the geographic concentration of donors around project sites as the outcome, drawing on data from [Bonica \(2024\)](#). Specifically, we substitute one of three outcomes into Equation 1: the mean contributor CFscore (where higher values indicate more conservative positions), Democratic share of distinct donors, and Democratic share of contributions. We restrict our analysis to contributions from the most recent election cycle.³⁶ This approach allows us to evaluate whether narrowly elected legislators disproportionately direct earmark requests to areas with many ideologically aligned donors.

Figure 11 reports the results. Across a battery of measures, we find no evidence of core co-partisan targeting. Whereas the registration benchmark shifts the targeted area roughly 15 percentiles up the Democratic-registration distribution, the effects on the ideology of nearby donors and on the Democratic share of nearby donors and contributions are all small and statistically indistinguishable from zero. Focusing on CFscores in the second row, our preferred measure of donor alignment, we find that the narrow election of a Democrat over a Republican does not change the composition of donors around requested projects. Our conclusions are highly similar when focusing on coarser measures of donor alignment in rows three and four. Appendix K further shows that this null result holds in the grid cell analysis from Section 6.2.2. When donor ideology and Democratic registration share are modeled jointly, partisan composition remains the only significant predictor of additional earmark

³⁶This restriction ensures our definition of donor base predates earmark requests themselves.

support, even after including socio-demographic covariates, grid cell fixed effects, and fiscal year fixed effects.

Taken together, these results provide no evidence that our central estimates reflect the targeting of core co-partisan constituents. Instead, our results are more consistent with legislators directing benefits toward electorally responsive co-partisan voters rather than their most committed partisan supporters.

7 Conclusion

Which constituents receive public resources is a central question in the study of distributive politics. A rich literature shows that electoral incentives shape how much government spending members of Congress secure for their districts, yet we know much less about how they distribute those resources among the constituents they represent. We study this question using congressional earmarks, a setting in which individual legislators exercise substantial discretion over the projects for which they seek federal funding. Pairing a new geocoded dataset of earmark requests and allocations with a regression discontinuity design in U.S. House elections, we find substantial evidence of co-partisan favoritism. Narrowly electing a Democrat over a Republican shifts the average earmark dollar towards areas with 8 percentage points higher Democratic registration, largely through a reallocation of requests away from out-party strongholds towards co-partisan areas. This disparity persists across policy areas, is not explained by the demographic correlates of partisanship, appears wherever representation changes hands rather than only in close districts, and carries through the appropriations process into enacted spending. We also present evidence that legislators do not target core co-partisans, as proxied by campaign donors, suggesting that our main effects are consistent with the targeting of swing co-partisan voters.

These findings complicate a common understanding of democratic accountability. Many theories suggest that elections—especially competitive ones—motivate politicians to work harder, adopt more responsive positions, and deliver for their districts. Empirical evidence that politicians in competitive districts secure more spending and are punished for poor performance is therefore often interpreted as evidence that electoral competition should induce better representation. Yet this interpretation generally carries an implicit assumption that politicians who work hard for their districts are working for the district as a whole. Our results challenge that assumption. Even in some of the most electorally competitive districts in the country, representatives direct more earmarks toward co-partisan communities than toward out-party ones within the same district. Electoral competition may therefore encourage legislator effort without ensuring equal representation.

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Online Appendix:

Partisan Favoritism in Public Spending: Evidence from Congressional Earmarks

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A Data on Congressional Earmark Requests

Our analysis uses project-level data on House Community Project Funding (CPF) requests for fiscal years 2022–2026. This period covers the post-moratorium years for which systematic House request data are available. Congress observed an earmark moratorium beginning with the 112th Congress (2011–2012). The moratorium ended for the FY2022 appropriations cycle, when the House Appropriations Committee revived earmarks under the new label “Community Project Funding.”³⁷ The revived process introduced several disclosure requirements. Members were required to post their CPF requests on their official House websites, the House Appropriations Committee released consolidated tables of submitted requests, and House rules required subcommittees to identify approved earmarks and their sponsors in the reports accompanying appropriations bills. We therefore begin with FY2022, the first fiscal year after the moratorium, and end with FY2026, the latest fiscal year for which a consolidated House request table was available when the dataset was constructed.

Under the post-moratorium regime, the CPF process begins when local governments, non-profit organizations, and other eligible project sponsors submit proposals to congressional offices. Project sponsors often submit the same proposal to both their House representative and their senators, while many members publish detailed application guidelines and outreach materials to solicit requests from their districts. In a typical appropriations cycle, applications to House offices are due in mid-March. Members then review the proposals they receive, select those they wish to sponsor, and transmit their requests to the relevant House Appropriations subcommittees, generally within approximately two weeks. The subcommittees subsequently determine which member-sponsored projects to include in the appropriations bills. Once the relevant bill is approved, funds are generally disbursed several months later. From the initial solicitation of constituent proposals through the eventual distribution of funds, the process therefore commonly extends for more than a year.

Several institutional rules constrain this process. House members may submit requests across multiple appropriations bills, but the total number of requests permitted per member increased over time: members could submit no more than 10 requests for FY2022, 15 for FY2023, and 20 in each fiscal year from FY2024 through FY2027. Senators face no equivalent submission cap. The 117th Congress administered the FY2022 and FY2023 appropriations cycles, the 118th Congress administered FY2024 and FY2025, and the 119th Congress administered FY2026 and FY2027. Aggregate earmark allocations were also subject to spending limits, with total allocations capped at 1 percent of discretionary spending in FY2022 and FY2023 and at 0.5 percent from FY2024 through FY2027. Within these constraints, individual appropriations subcommittees retain authority to establish their own eligibility requirements and evaluation criteria. Although these rules vary across subcommittees, funding decisions are intended to follow pre-established substantive guidelines rather than member-specific considerations.

A.1 Primary Sources and Harmonization

The primary sources are the House Appropriations Committee’s consolidated CPF request tables for FY2022–FY2026. The FY2022 and FY2023 files are hosted on the Democratic

³⁷The Senate uses the term “Congressionally Directed Spending.”

House Appropriations Committee website, while the FY2024–FY2026 files are hosted on the Republican House Appropriations Committee website. These tables report, for each CPF request, the member name, subcommittee, project name and/or description, requested amount, recipient name, and, depending on the year, the member’s district, party, disclosure website, and the project recipient’s address.

We harmonized the annual files into a common schema containing congress session, fiscal year, member name, district, party, project, recipient, address, requested amount, member disclosure website, and geocoordinates. The source files differ in the variables reported. While the FY2024–FY2026 files contain the full set of variables described above, the FY2022 and FY2023 files do not contain member information beyond member names. Critically, FY2023 does not include recipient addresses in the consolidated table, requiring us to recover address information from member disclosure pages and other project-level source materials. The raw stacked dataset contains 23,510 CPF requests totaling \$85.38 billion in requested funds. Table A.1 summarizes the source data before address recovery.

Table A.1 – House Community Project Funding Requests Before Address Recovery

FY	Number of Requests	Requested Amount	Missing Address in Source
2022	3,019	\$7.13b	95
2023	4,761	\$12.40b	4,761
2024	5,067	\$19.38b	34
2025	5,249	\$23.07b	72
2026	5,414	\$23.39b	71
Total	23,510	\$85.38b	5,033

A.2 Recovering Missing Addresses

For projects missing addresses, we collected project-location information from member disclosure materials. Our address-recovery process involved four steps. First, for each member-fiscal-year with at least one missing address in the consolidated source tables, we used an iterative retrieval-and-screening procedure to identify the relevant disclosure material. We began with the member’s official CPF disclosure page, using the live page when available and otherwise querying the Internet Archive Wayback Machine for snapshots from July–December of the year preceding the fiscal year. This window follows the closing of the request process, when members were expected to have posted their CPF disclosures on their official House websites. Member disclosure URLs are included in the consolidated data for FY2024–FY2026. For FY2022 and FY2023, which do not include these links, we scraped the Democratic Committee’s centralized member-link pages to recover members’ disclosure URLs.

We then used a large language model (LLM) to screen each retrieved document for project-level CPF information for the target fiscal year.³⁸ To pass screening, a document had to list at least one specific project for that fiscal year, including a project name or description and a recipient or project address. The implementation used separate HTML and

³⁸The screening step used Claude Sonnet 4.6.

PDF screening prompts to identify the input type, but both applied the same substantive screening prompt. If a retrieved document was too thin to contain project-level content, failed screening, or pointed to separate disclosure materials, we searched for a relevant CPF subpage or downloaded linked financial certification PDFs, which members are required to submit to certify that they and their immediate families have no financial interest in the requested projects. Retrieved subpages and PDFs were then screened using the same criteria. When the automated search returned an incorrect or incomplete page and no linked PDF or relevant subpage could be found, we allowed manual URL overrides as a final fallback. Of the 479 member-fiscal years with at least one missing address, we identified usable disclosure documents for 461 (96.2%).

Screening prompt

This is a document from a US House member’s Community Project Funding disclosure for FY {fy}.

Does this document contain project-level information for FY {fy}? To qualify, the document must list at least one specific project covering FY {fy} with (1) a project name or project description and (2) a recipient address or project address.

Note: Formal project request letters dated {fy - 1} and written by the member to the Appropriations Committee always qualify if they contain the above information.

Reply with only: YES or NO.

For documents that passed the screening step, we used a second LLM call to extract structured project-level fields.³⁹ These fields include the project name, project description, project purpose, recipient, project address, recipient address, and the requested amount. The model extracted 6,372 projects from the retrieved documents, of which 6,136 (96.3%) contained location information.

Extraction prompt

Extract project-level information from U.S. House member {member}’s disclosure document for FY {fy} Community Project Funding requests.

Cover letter check: If this document is a member letter to a congressional committee or subcommittee, extract only projects from letters dated in {fy - 1}. Skip letters dated in other years. If no letters are dated in {fy - 1}, return:

```
{
  "projects": [],
  "note": "incorrect FY - letters dated [year]"
}
```

Extract one object for each distinct project mentioned in the document. Return JSON with one key, "projects", containing one object per distinct project:

```
{
  "projects": [
```

³⁹The extraction step used Claude Opus 4.7.

```

    {
      "project_name": null,
      "project_description": null,
      "project_purpose": null,
      "recipient": null,
      "project_address": null,
      "recipient_address": null,
      "amount_requested": null,
      "source_notes": null
    }
  ]
}

```

Use `null` for any field that is not stated.

Rules:

- Return one object per distinct project.
- Do not merge multiple projects into one object.
- Do not infer facts not explicitly stated.
- Preserve dollar amounts exactly as written.
- If the same project appears more than once, extract it only once using whichever instance has the most complete information.
- Use `project_description` for the main descriptive text by default.
- Use `project_purpose` only if the document separately states a purpose or use of funds.
- Use `project_address` as the default address field.
- If it is unclear whether the address is for the project or recipient, put it in `project_address`.
- Use `recipient_address` only when the document clearly states a recipient address that is different from `project_address`.
- Use `source_notes` only for brief notes about ambiguity or unusual wording.

If there are no projects to extract, return:

```

{
  "projects": []
}

```

When `projects` is empty, you may include a top-level `"note"` field briefly explaining why, for example:

```

{
  "projects": [],
  "note": "<brie f reason>"
}

```

Return ONLY valid JSON, no other text. Do not wrap the output in markdown code fences.

Finally, we matched the extracted projects back to the harmonized source data using a constrained LLM matching prompt.⁴⁰ For each member-fiscal-year, the prompt listed source projects with missing addresses (with project name, recipient, and requested amount) alongside all extracted projects for the same member-fiscal-year with available address information

⁴⁰The matching step used Claude Opus 4.7.

(with project name, description, purpose, recipient, and requested amount). The model was instructed to match each source project to the best corresponding extracted project, with each extracted project assigned to at most one source row. This matching process recovered addresses for 4,663 of the 5,033 projects that initially lacked addresses, including 4,408 high-confidence matches, 243 medium-confidence matches, and 12 low-confidence matches. We manually reviewed all low-confidence matches and a 10% random sample of medium-confidence matches. All reviewed matches were correctly assigned. Table A.2 summarizes the distribution of recovered and remaining missing addresses by fiscal year.

Matching prompt

You are helping fill in missing addresses for earmark projects requested by {member} for FY {fy}.

Below are projects missing addresses, labeled REQUESTED, and projects scraped from official disclosure documents that have addresses, labeled EXTRACTED. For each requested project, find the best extracted match so we can obtain its address. Return null if no extracted project is a plausible match.

REQUESTED PROJECTS (missing addresses):

[1]

Project: <project name>
Description: <project description, if available>
Recipient: <recipient name>
Amount: <amount requested>

...

[N]

Project: <project name>
Description: <project description, if available>
Recipient: <recipient name>
Amount: <amount requested>

EXTRACTED PROJECTS (have addresses):

[1]

Project: <project name>
Description: <project description>
Purpose: <project purpose, if available>
Recipient: <recipient name>
Project address: <project address>
Amount: <amount requested>

...

[N]

Project: <project name>
Description: <project description>
Purpose: <project purpose, if available>
Recipient: <recipient name>
Project address: <project address>
Amount: <amount requested>

Each extracted project may only be matched to one requested project. If two requested projects could match the same extracted project, assign it to the closer match and return "ex": null for the other.

Return ONLY valid JSON in the following format:

```
{
  "matches": [
    {
      "stk": 1,
      "ex": 2,
      "confidence": "high"
    }
  ]
}
```

Use "ex": null if no extracted project is a plausible match.

Confidence definitions:

- "high": certain same project.
- "medium": likely same project.
- "low": possible same project.

Table A.2 – Address Recovery from Member Disclosure Materials

FY	Missing in Source	Recovered	Remaining Missing
2022	95	88	7
2023	4,761	4,435	326
2024	34	24	10
2025	72	62	10
2026	71	54	17
Total	5,033	4,663	370

A.3 Classifying Policy Area

Although each request is assigned to an appropriations subcommittee, subcommittee labels are too coarse to capture the substantive purpose of individual projects. For example, a single subcommittee such as “Transportation, Housing and Urban Development” receives requests for projects including road improvements, public transit, affordable housing, and community development. To support the within-category analysis in Section 6.1, we classify every request into one of twelve substantive policy areas that are finer than the subcommittee designation.

To do so, we identify eleven major policy areas and develop a codebook listing representative projects in each area.⁴¹ Table A.3 reproduces the codebook. For the classification step, we prompt OpenAI’s GPT-5.5 large language model to classify each earmark request based on the project title using the codebook. The third column in Table A.3 reports the number

⁴¹We also construct a residual *Other* category. Only 0.6 percent of requests fall into this category.

of projects classified into each policy area. To validate our classifications, we independently hand-coded a random sample of 150 requests using the same codebook, blind to the model’s classifications. Our human coding and the model agreed on 88 percent of requests. Because some agreement is expected by chance, we summarize concordance with Cohen’s κ , which adjusts for chance agreement. The resulting κ of 0.86 indicates strong agreement between human coders and the model.

To further describe the policy areas, Figure A.1 shows the most frequent project-name words within each policy area.

Table A.3 – Policy-Area Codebook

Category	Description	Requests
Utilities	Water, sewer, and stormwater systems; flood control, levees, and dam safety; broadband and last-mile internet	4,949
Infrastructure	Roads, bridges, highways, and bike/pedestrian paths; buses, rail, and transit hubs	4,014
Public safety	Police, fire, and EMS equipment and facilities; emergency operations and communications	3,231
Human services	Affordable housing; food banks, homeless services, and family, youth, and senior programs	2,479
Community facility	Community centers, libraries, parks, trails, recreation facilities, and museums	2,450
Education & research	K–12 and higher education, workforce-training programs, and research facilities	2,386
Health	Hospitals, clinics, community health centers, and mental-health and substance-use treatment	1,256
Economic development	Downtown revitalization, business incubators, workforce facilities, and public-works buildings	1,145
Aviation & maritime	Airports and runways; ports, harbors, dredging, and navigation channels; freight rail	873
Environment	Habitat and watershed restoration and land and marine conservation	440
Military construction	Military bases, barracks, and on-base training and construction	209
Other	Unclassifiable, multi-purpose, or insufficient information	142
Total		23,574

A.4 Member Matching and Geocoding

We matched each request to Voteview House rosters for the 117th, 118th, and 119th Congresses. This step supplied Bioguide identifiers, member state, district, and party for all rows, including FY2022–FY2023 observations for which district and party were not reported in the original source tables. The matching procedure used a cascade of name and state keys. The final match rate was 100% across 519 unique members serving in the 117th, 118th, or

Figure A.1 – Most Frequent Words in Earmark Project Names, by Policy Category. Each panel shows the top 35 words from the project names within the labeled policy category. Word size and color encode the within-category rank of each word’s frequency.



119th Congress. These members represent 85% of the 610 Voteview House members who served across the three Congresses.

We geocoded CPF requests using the ArcGIS USA geocoder. For the 17 projects that listed multiple distinct sites in a single address field, we expanded the data to one row per location and divided the requested amount equally across sites.⁴² The final dataset therefore contains 23,574 location rows corresponding to 23,510 distinct project requests, and the geocoder returned coordinates for 23,132 of 23,574 location rows, a 98% match rate. Most matches are highly granular: over 90% were matched at the street and point levels. The level of granularity in geocoordinates by fiscal year is shown in Table A.4. We also flag cases in which the geocoded state differs from the sponsoring member’s state. This occurs for 237 location rows (1.0%), often reflecting headquarters or administrative addresses rather than project sites.

⁴²For example, Representative Jimmy Gomez’s FY2023 CPF request for “Community Empowerment Learning Pods” was designated for three YMCAs in the Los Angeles area: Weingart East Los Angeles YMCA at 2900 Whittier Boulevard, Ketchum-Downtown YMCA at 401 South Hope Street, and Anderson-Munger Family YMCA at 4301 West Third Street. We split this request into three location rows with a common project identifier.

Table A.4 – Geocoding Results

FY	Total	Point	Street	City/Postal	Unmatched
2022	3,041	2,662	242	130	7
2023	4,801	3,631	522	308	340
2024	5,069	4,360	518	154	37
2025	5,249	4,559	498	151	41
2026	5,414	4,700	529	168	17
Total	23,574	19,912	2,309	911	442

B Data on Congressional Earmark Allocations

We supplement the House request data with project-level records of enacted earmark allocations. These records allow us to identify whether each requested project was ultimately funded and, when it was funded, the amount provided by Congress. Our primary sources are the subcommittee-level Community Project Funding and Congressionally Directed Spending tables released as PDFs on the Senate Appropriations Committee’s website. Unlike the House request tables, which record all projects submitted by House members, the Senate tables contain only projects included in the final appropriations legislation. Depending on the fiscal year and subcommittee, the tables report the appropriations agency and account, project name or description, recipient, state, requesting House and Senate members, chamber of origination, and final amount provided. We recover allocations for FY2022, FY2023, FY2024, and FY2026. For FY2025, however, allocations are unavailable because Congress did not fund any earmarks due to a series of continuing resolutions.

B.1 Sources for Funded Projects

The allocation PDFs differ across fiscal years and subcommittees in their layout, column names, and treatment of project and recipient information. Some files contain separate project and recipient columns, while others combine both in a single description field. The files also differ in whether dollar amounts are reported in dollars or thousands of dollars, and some are scanned documents without a usable text layer. We therefore use an LLM-assisted procedure to extract each funded project into a common schema.⁴³

For each fiscal year, we process every available subcommittee PDF in batches of eight pages. The model reads the PDF pages directly, including pages that must be rendered as images, and returns one structured record for each funded project. The standardized fields are fiscal year, subcommittee, agency, account, project, recipient, amount, state, House requester, Senate requester, and chamber of origination. The prompt instructs the model to preserve the table’s distinctions when they are available, leave fields empty when the source contains no corresponding information, and avoid combining, summarizing, or inferring project records. Each page batch is saved separately, and the annual file is assembled only after every expected batch has been successfully extracted.

Allocation extraction prompt

You are extracting a U.S. congressional appropriations earmarks disclosure table from a PDF or a page-range fragment of one. Read every page of the PDF at `pdf path`.

It is a Community Project Funding or Congressionally Directed Spending allocations table. Each data row is one funded project. These tables appear in several layouts and do not all contain the same columns. Map whatever columns this PDF contains onto the fixed target schema below; if a target field has no corresponding column or content, use an empty string.

Return a JSON object with exactly two keys. The first is `amounts_in_thousands`: use `true` if a header or subtitle visible on these pages states that dollar amounts are reported in thousands; `false` if a table header or subtitle is visible and does not state that amounts are

⁴³The allocation extraction step used Claude Opus 4.8.

in thousands; and `null` if these pages show no header text about units. Do not infer units from the size of the numbers. The second key is `rows`, a JSON array containing one object per funded project:

```
{
  "amounts_in_thousands": true | false | null,
  "rows": [
    {
      "agency": "",
      "account": "",
      "project": "",
      "recipient": "",
      "amount": "",
      "state": "",
      "house_member": "",
      "senate_member": "",
      "origination": ""
    }
  ]
}
```

Field rules:

- Use **agency** for the agency or department and **account** for the appropriations account. Use an empty string when either field is absent.
- Use **project** for the project description or name. If the table combines the project and recipient in a single column, place the full combined text in **project** and leave **recipient** empty.
- Use **recipient** only when the table contains a distinct recipient column. If it instead reports a project site or base location in a separate location column, place that location in **recipient**.
- Record **amount** exactly as printed using digits only. Do not convert values reported in thousands.
- Record **state** as a two-letter postal abbreviation. Prefer an explicit state column; otherwise use clear location text or a requester state annotation when unambiguous.
- Separate multiple House or Senate requester names with semicolons and preserve state annotations attached to names. If the table has a single combined requester column, place the names in the chamber field indicated by **origination**.
- Record **origination** as H, S, or H/S.

Rejoin words hyphenated across line breaks while preserving genuine hyphens. Ignore repeated page headers, section-title banners, column-header rows, and subtotal or total lines. Extract every project row; do not invent, merge, or summarize rows. Return only valid JSON.

After extraction, we combine the page-level records within each fiscal year and assign a standardized subcommittee name based on the source file. We also standardize the units in which allocations are reported. For each page batch, the model records whether an explicit header states that amounts are in thousands of dollars. Batches containing continuation pages without a table header inherit the unit designation from other batches belonging to the same subcommittee; when no batch contains unit information, the values are treated as dollars. As an independent check, we search the PDF text layer for language indicating that values are reported in thousands and flag disagreements with the model's classification. If different header-bearing batches from the same subcommittee produce contradictory unit

designations, the annual file is not assembled until the discrepancy is resolved. Amounts from subcommittees identified as reporting in thousands are then multiplied by 1,000, producing a common measure of final dollars allocated.

The enacted-earmark universe we extract comprises 28,775 allocation records worth \$58.09 billion across FY2022–FY2024 and FY2026. Annual volume rises over the panel, from 4,975 records and \$9.69 billion in FY2022 to 8,485 records and \$16.72 billion in FY2026, with the median award steady at roughly \$1 million; Table B.1 reports the breakdown. Of these, 16,755 records worth \$30.59 billion list at least one House sponsor and are therefore in scope for matching to House members’ requests.

Table B.1 – Allocation records and enacted spending. Projects which received funding as extracted from the Senate Appropriations Community Project Funding / Congressionally Directed Spending disclosure tables, before any match to requests. FY2025 is absent due to Congress not funding any requests for that fiscal year. Amounts are reported in dollars. Columns denoted “House-sponsored” restrict to allocations listing at least one House sponsor, the subset the matcher operates on; the remainder are Senate-only.

FY	Allocations	Allocated Amount	Median Award	House-Sponsored Allocations	House-Sponsored Amount
2022	4,975	\$9.69b	\$0.93m	2,724	\$4.22b
2023	7,218	\$15.92b	\$1.00m	4,357	\$8.80b
2024	8,097	\$15.77b	\$0.97m	4,686	\$8.59b
2026	8,485	\$16.72b	\$1.00m	4,988	\$8.96b
Total	28,775	\$58.09b	\$1.00m	16,755	\$30.59b

B.2 Matching Final Allocations to House Requests

We next match the extracted allocations to the corresponding projects in the House requests data. The matching procedure is conducted separately for each House member and fiscal year. We first restrict the possible matches to allocations from the same fiscal year for which the member is listed as a House requester. To accommodate differences in how member names are printed across sources, we normalize capitalization, diacritics, and apostrophes before identifying surname matches. We also use the allocation state and state annotations attached to requester names to distinguish members who share a surname.

For each member-fiscal-year, we use a constrained LLM matching prompt to compare the member’s requests with the resulting pool of possible allocations.⁴⁴ The request records include the project name, recipient, cleaned address, subcommittee, and requested amount. The allocation records include the project name, recipient, state, subcommittee, agency, account, final amount, and listed House requester. The model is instructed to consider these fields jointly, rather than treating agreement on any single field as sufficient, and to return no match when an allocation does not plausibly fund the same project. Each allocation may

⁴⁴The allocation matching step used Claude Opus 4.7.

be linked to at most one request within a member-fiscal-year. The code separately enforces this restriction after the model returns its proposed matches.

Allocation matching prompt

You are matching earmark requests submitted by U.S. Representative **member** for FY **fy** to enacted allocations in the same fiscal year. Below are the member's requested projects and the pool of allocations for which this member is listed as a House sponsor. For each request, identify the allocation that funds the same project. Match on the project name, recipient, address or state, subcommittee, and dollar amounts together; no single field is definitive. Return **null** if no allocation plausibly matches.

REQUESTS:

```
[1]
Project:      <project name>
Recipient:    <recipient name>
Address:      <cleaned project address>
Subcommittee: <subcommittee>
Amount req:   <requested amount>
```

ALLOCATIONS:

```
[1]
Project:      <project name>
Recipient:    <recipient name>
State:        <state>
Subcommittee: <subcommittee>
Agency:      <agency>
Account:      <account>
Amount:       <final allocation>
House member: <listed House requester>
```

Each allocation may be matched to only one request. If two requests could match the same allocation, assign it to the closer match and return **null** for the other. Return only valid JSON in the following format:

```
{
  "matches": [
    {
      "req": 1,
      "alloc": 2,
      "confidence": "high"
    }
  ]
}
```

Use "alloc": **null** when no allocation is a plausible match. Classify confidence as **high** when the records certainly describe the same project, **medium** when they likely describe the same project, and **low** when the match is only possible.

Requests linked to an enacted allocation are coded as funded and assigned the final amount reported in the allocation table. Requests for which the member has no candidate allocations, or for which no candidate plausibly describes the same project, are coded as unfunded. Because the resulting data remain organized around House requests, Senate-only allocations and other allocation records that cannot be linked to a House request are not added as separate observations. When a funded project lists multiple House requesters, the

allocation may be linked separately to the corresponding request of each listed member; the one-to-one restriction applies within each member-fiscal-year. The matching procedure records high-, medium-, and low-confidence matches and produces a separate file containing all low-confidence assignments for manual review. The final request-level dataset preserves the original request information and adds two variables: an indicator for whether the request was funded and the amount ultimately provided by Congress.

Table B.2 reports that the allocations-to-requests match rate is extremely high. Of the collected allocations, 16,596 of 16,755 House-sponsored allocations (99.1%) correspond to a House request. The match rate rises monotonically from 97.8% in FY2022 to 99.6% in FY2026.

Table B.2 – Enacted Earmarks Matched to a Member’s Funding Request. Of all enacted earmarks listing a House sponsor, the share linked to a request filed by that sponsor. Amounts are de-duplicated across jointly sponsored earmarks.

FY	House-Sponsored Allocations	Matched to a Request	Share Matched	Share Low-Confidence
2022	2,724	2,665	97.8%	0.08%
2023	4,357	4,311	98.9%	0.00%
2024	4,686	4,651	99.3%	0.02%
2026	4,988	4,969	99.6%	0.00%
Total	16,755	16,596	99.1%	0.02%

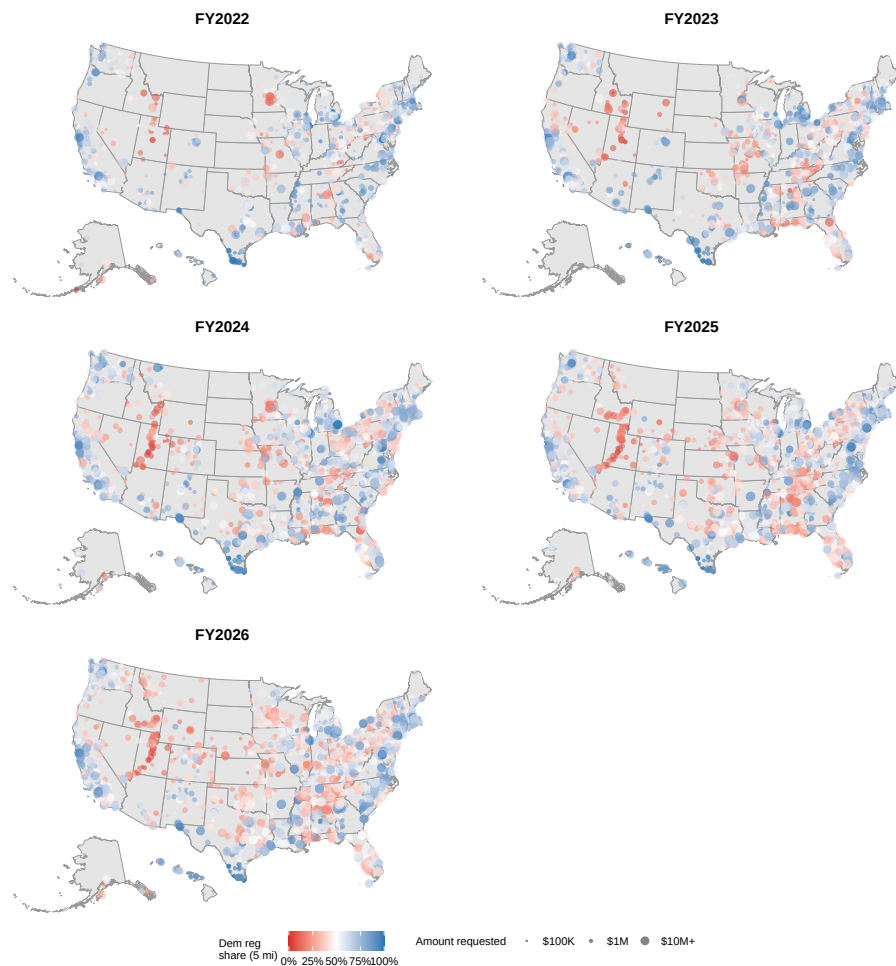
C Additional Earmark Descriptives

This appendix reports additional descriptive information on where earmarks are requested and allocated.

C.1 Earmark Requests

Figure C.1 breaks the results in Figure 1 out by fiscal year.

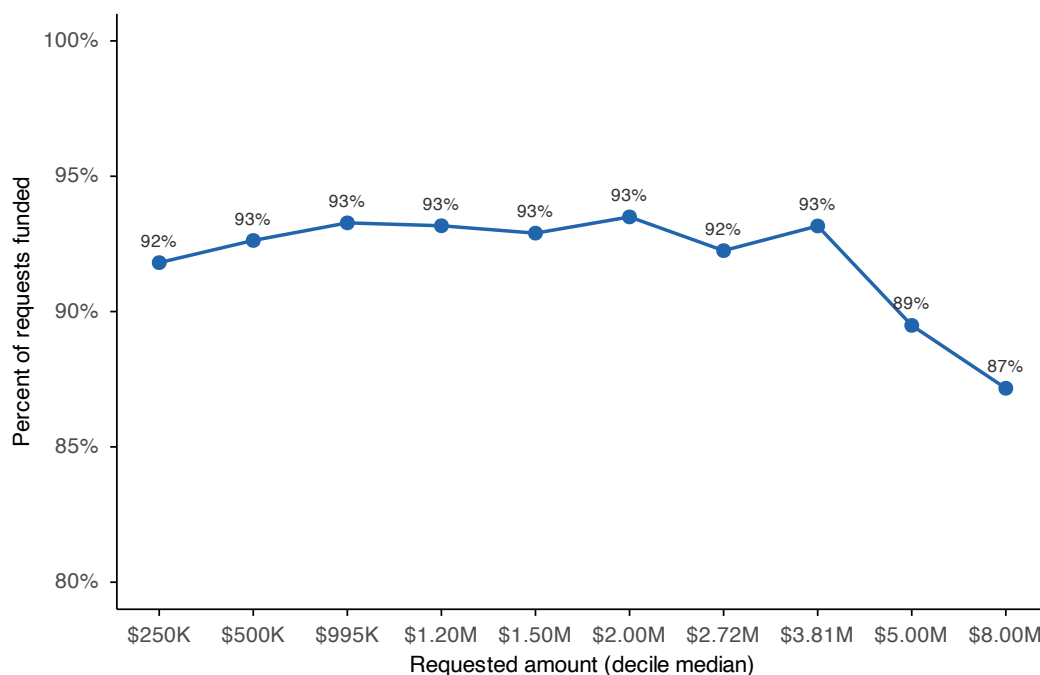
Figure C.1 – Geographic Distribution of Earmark Requests by Fiscal Year, Colored by Democratic Registration Share Within 5 Miles. Each dot represents an individual earmark request; dot area is proportional to the requested amount (capped at \$10 million for scaling) and color encodes the Democratic registration share within five miles of the project. Panels break out the pooled map in Figure 1 by fiscal year, FY2022–FY2026. Alaska and Hawaii are repositioned beneath the continental United States.



C.2 Earmark Allocations

Figure C.2 examines whether larger requests are less likely to be funded. It plots the percent of requests receiving any allocation by decile of the requested amount, pooling all fiscal years with enacted earmarks. Funding rates are flat at roughly 92–93% through the first eight deciles and decline only for the largest requests, falling to 87% in the top decile.

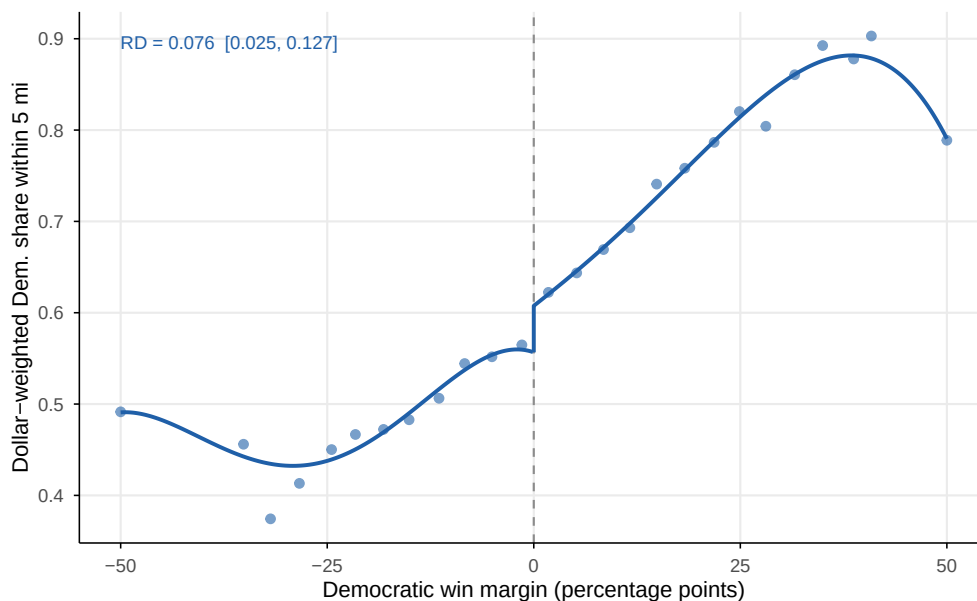
Figure C.2 – Funding Rate by Size of Request. Percent of earmark requests receiving any funding, by decile of the requested amount (FY2022–FY2026 pooled; FY2025 excluded because no earmarks were enacted). The horizontal axis reports each decile’s median requested amount.



D Visualizing the Discontinuity

Figure D.1 presents the standard graphical version of our headline estimate. It plots binned means of the dollar-weighted Democratic registration share within five miles of requested projects against the Democratic margin of victory, with a fourth-order polynomial fit separately on each side of the threshold. The partisan composition of requested projects rises visibly and discontinuously as the seat passes from Republican to Democratic control, consistent with the estimates in Figure 5 and Table 1.

Figure D.1 – Democratic Registration Share Near Earmark Requests, by Democratic Margin of Victory (5-Mile Radius). Each point is the mean dollar-weighted Democratic registration share within five miles of requested projects among district-years in that bin of the Democratic two-party margin, using fifteen evenly spaced bins on each side of the threshold. Lines are fourth-order polynomials fit separately on each side. The annotation reports the bias-corrected CCT estimate of β_1 from Equation 2 with its robust 95% confidence interval, matching the first column of Table 1.



E RD Design Diagnostics

We evaluate whether the running-variable density is continuous at the treatment threshold using the local-polynomial density-discontinuity procedure developed by [Cattaneo et al. \(2020\)](#). We implement the test with the `rddensity` package, which builds on the logic of [McCrary \(2008\)](#). Applied to our headline sample, the test yields a p-value of 0.64, providing no evidence of sorting around the close-election cutoff.

Unfortunately, we cannot report a lagged-outcome balance test because the modern ear-mark panel does not provide a comparable lag for two of its three election cohorts. The program has no pre-2020-cycle requests, and the 2020-to-2022 comparison crosses the decennial redistricting boundary, so matching districts by number would link different geographic units. We note, however, that this limitation is strongly mitigated by prior evidence finding little systematic sorting around close-election thresholds in U.S. House races ([Eggers et al., 2015](#)).

F Robustness to the Measurement of Neighborhood Partisanship

In 33 states, L2’s partisan classification reflects voters’ self-declared party affiliation as recorded in the state’s official voter-registration file, or the party of the most recent primary in which they participated. In the remaining 17 states, L2 imputes partisan classification using a proprietary model trained on primary-ballot choice and demographic data. To evaluate the robustness of our results, we replicate our main analysis using a measure of voters’ political preferences as revealed through presidential election returns. Using geolocated precinct-level returns from the 2020 presidential election collected by the Voting and Election Science Team (VEST), we calculate *Dem Presidential Vote Share* $_{pdt}^r$, the Democratic candidate’s two-party vote share within r miles of project p in district d and cycle t . When precincts are not entirely contained within a given radius, we weight each precinct by the share of its area lying inside the r -mile buffer. We then substitute this measure into Equation 1.

Table F.1 reports the results using this alternative measure of partisanship. Our point estimates remain statistically distinguishable from zero across all four specifications, but are slightly smaller than the estimates using voter registration data. This smaller magnitude is consistent with the fact that presidential vote share is a coarser proxy for neighborhood partisanship than registration.

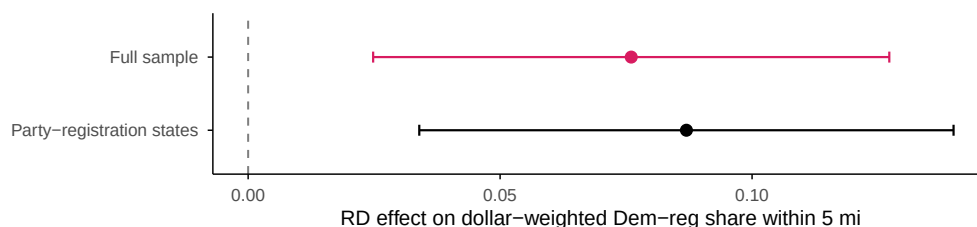
A second check restricts the sample rather than replacing the measure. Figure F.1 re-estimates our preferred 5-mile specification using only the 30 states that register voters by party, where L2’s party field reproduces each state’s official registration-by-party counts nearly exactly and involves no modeling. The estimate rises slightly to 8.7 percentage points (robust $p < 0.001$) despite discarding roughly 40% of the sample. Our headline result is therefore not an artifact of L2’s imputed partisanship in the remaining states.

Table F.1 – Effect of Electing a Democrat on Democratic Two-Party Presidential Vote Share Near Earmark Requests, 5-Mile Radius. This table replicates Table 1 using the two-party Democratic presidential vote share instead of party registration to measure partisanship. Our substantive conclusions remain unchanged using this measure of revealed political preferences.

	Dollar-Weighted Democratic Presidential Vote Share			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Democratic Win	0.03 (0.01)	0.02 (0.01)	0.03 (0.01)	0.02 (0.01)
N	396	356	993	993
Specification	CCT	Linear	Cubic	IW
Spline	-	Yes	Yes	-
Bandwidth	0.11	0.10	-	-

Note: District-regime-clustered robust standard errors are reported in parentheses in columns (1)–(3). IW does not support clustered inference; its parenthesized value is the 95% confidence-interval half-length divided by 1.96. The outcome is the dollar-weighted Democratic two-party presidential vote share within five miles of a district-year’s requested earmark projects. The running variable is the Democratic candidate’s general-election margin of victory. Spline indicates that the regression function was fit separately on either side of zero. Cubic refers to a third-order polynomial regression. CCT refers to the method from Calonico, Cattaneo, and Titiunik (2014). IW refers to the method from Imbens and Wager (2019).

Figure F.1 – Effect of Electing a Democrat on the Dollar-Weighted Democratic Registration Share Near Earmark Requests, Party-Registration States Only (5-Mile Radius). CCT regression-discontinuity estimates of β_1 from Equation 2 with robust 95% confidence intervals. The bottom row restricts the sample to the 30 states whose voter-registration files record party affiliation, where L2 reports the state’s recorded party rather than a modeled classification. The “Full sample” estimate (red) matches Figure 5.



G Extensive Margin Estimates

A potential concern in Equation 1 is that a small number of large earmark requests might be driving our results. In this section we re-estimate our main results after weighting each project equally. Formally, our outcome becomes

$$Y_{dt}^r = \frac{\sum_{p \in P_{dt}} \text{Dem Registration Share}_{pdt}^r}{|P_{dt}|}, \quad (\text{G.1})$$

where $|P_{dt}|$ represents the number of requested projects. In words, each requested project enters the district-year outcome with equal weight, regardless of the size of the request.

We first replicate Table 1 using this unweighted outcome at the 5-mile radius. Table G.1 reports the resulting estimates. The point estimates are highly similar to their dollar-weighted counterparts in Table 1, indicating that the headline result is not driven by variation in the size of individual requests.

To confirm that this finding is not specific to the 5-mile buffer, Figure G.1 replicates Figure 5 using the unweighted outcome across radii 1–15 miles. The point estimates closely track those in Figure 5 and are positive and statistically distinguishable from zero at every radius, confirming that the headline pattern is robust to dropping the dollar weighting.

The same logic applies to the bucketed composition result in Figure 6, which reports the effect of electing a Democrat on the share of *dollars* flowing to Dem-heavy, Bipartisan, and Rep-heavy neighborhoods at the 5-mile radius. Figure G.2 replicates that figure using the share of *projects* in each neighborhood type rather than the share of requested dollars. The point estimates are similar in sign and magnitude to those in Figure 6, again confirming that the headline composition pattern does not depend on the dollar weighting.

Table G.1 – Effect of Electing a Democrat on Unweighted Democratic Registration Share, 5-Mile Radius. The narrow election of a Democrat shifts the average share of Democratic registrants within 5 miles of requested projects by 4 to 6 percentage points.

	Unweighted Dem Registration Share			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Dem. Win	0.06 (0.03)	0.05 (0.02)	0.04 (0.02)	0.05 (0.02)
N	279	356	993	993
Specification	CCT	Linear	Cubic	IW
Spline	-	Yes	Yes	-
Bandwidth	0.08	0.10	-	-

Note: District-regime-clustered robust standard errors are reported in parentheses in columns (1)–(3). IW does not support clustered inference; its parenthesized value is the 95% confidence-interval half-length divided by 1.96. The outcome is the average Democratic registration share within 5 miles of a district-year’s requested earmark projects (unweighted). The running variable is the Democratic candidate’s general-election margin of victory. Spline indicates that the regression function was fit separately on either side of zero. Cubic refers to a third-order polynomial regression. CCT refers to the method from Calonico, Cattaneo, and Titiunik (2014). IW refers to the method from Imbens and Wager (2019).

Figure G.1 – Effect of Electing a Democrat on the Project-Equally-Weighted Democratic Share of Nearby Registrants, by Radius. The narrow election of a Democratic member of Congress increases the unweighted two-party Democratic share of registered voters in the vicinity of earmark requests by 5 to 7 percentage points relative to electing a Republican. The horizontal axis reports the radius of voters included around each project. Replicates Figure 5 after replacing dollar weighting with equal weighting across projects.

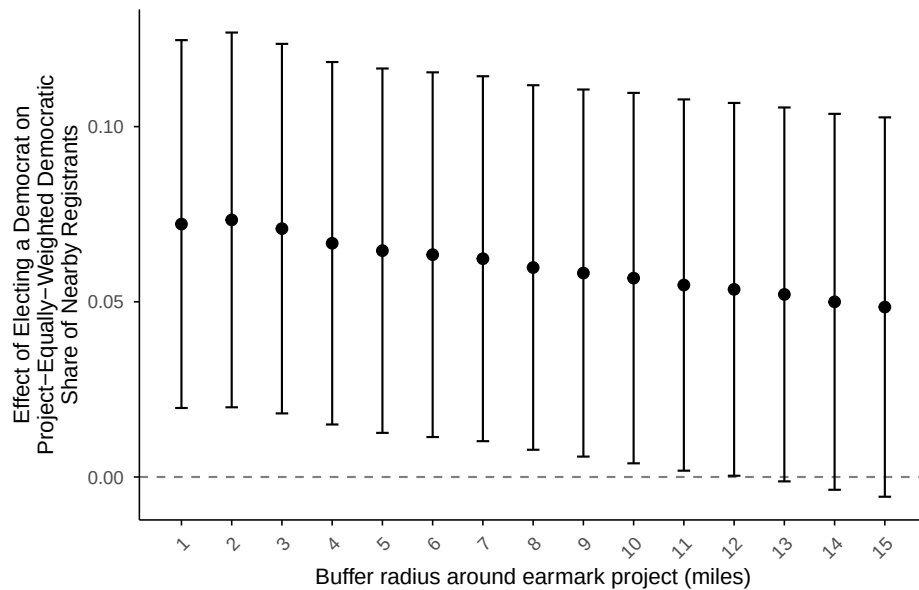
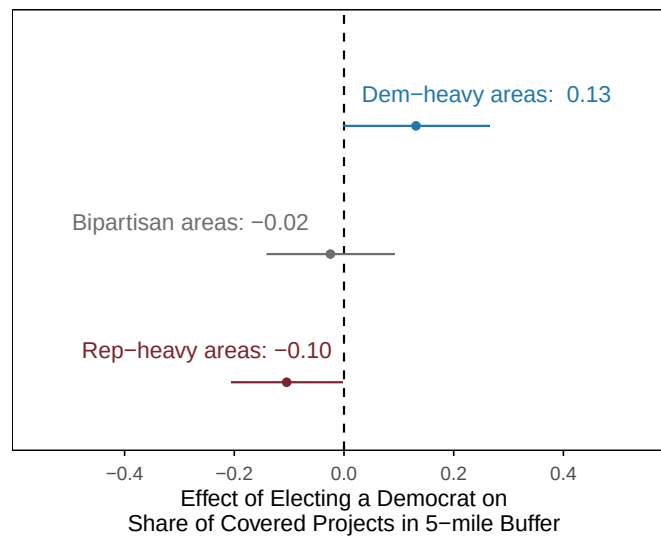


Figure G.2 – Effect of Electing a Democrat on the Share of Projects Placed in Each Neighborhood Type, 5-Mile Radius. Robust bias-corrected RDD estimates (Calonico et al., 2014) of the effect of a narrow Democratic win on the district-year share of earmark projects (rather than requested dollars) whose 5-mile buffer falls in each partisan bucket: Dem-heavy ($> 60\%$ Dem registration), Bipartisan ($40\text{--}60\%$, endpoints included), or Rep-heavy ($< 40\%$). 95% robust confidence intervals shown. The narrow election of a Democratic member of Congress increases the share of earmark projects requested in Democratic-heavy areas by 13 percentage points, while decreasing the share of projects in Republican-heavy areas by 10 percentage points; the smaller 2-percentage-point decline in bipartisan areas is not statistically distinguishable from zero.



H Estimates by Subcommittee

A natural question is whether the co-partisan targeting documented in Figure 5 is confined to a handful of spending areas or holds broadly across the appropriations process. Figure H.1 re-estimates Equation 2 separately within each House Appropriations subcommittee to which requests were directed, using the dollar-weighted Democratic registration share within a 5-mile radius and the estimator from [Calonico et al. \(2014\)](#). The top row (in red) reproduces the pooled estimate from Figure 5.

Figure H.1 – Effect of Electing a Democrat on the Dollar-Weighted Democratic Registration Share Near Earmark Requests, by Appropriations Subcommittee (5-Mile Radius). Each point is a separate CCT regression-discontinuity estimate of β_1 from Equation 2, restricting the earmark requests to those directed to the labeled subcommittee; horizontal bars are robust 95% confidence intervals. The pooled “All subcommittees” estimate (red) matches Figure 5.

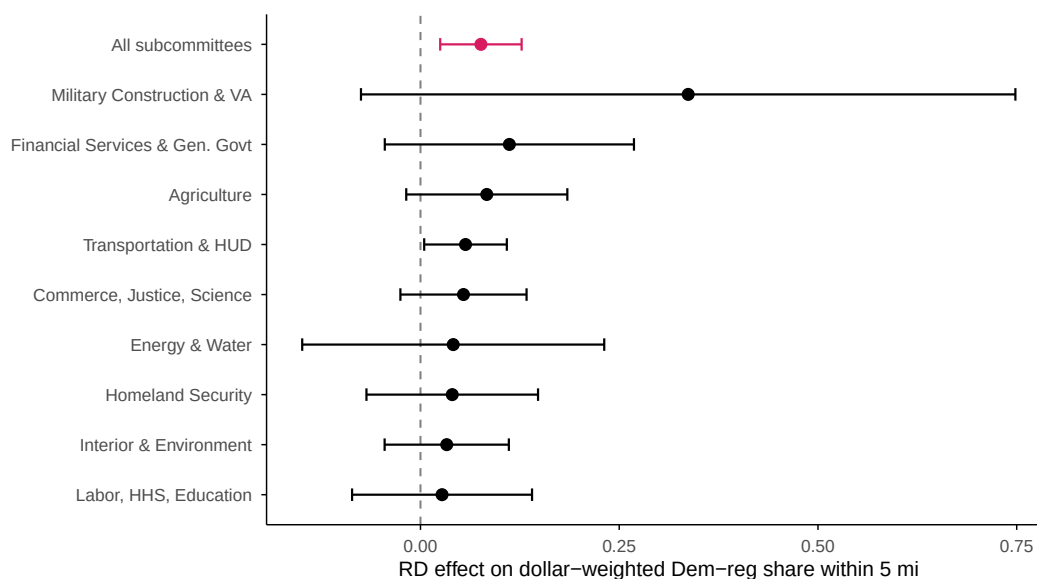
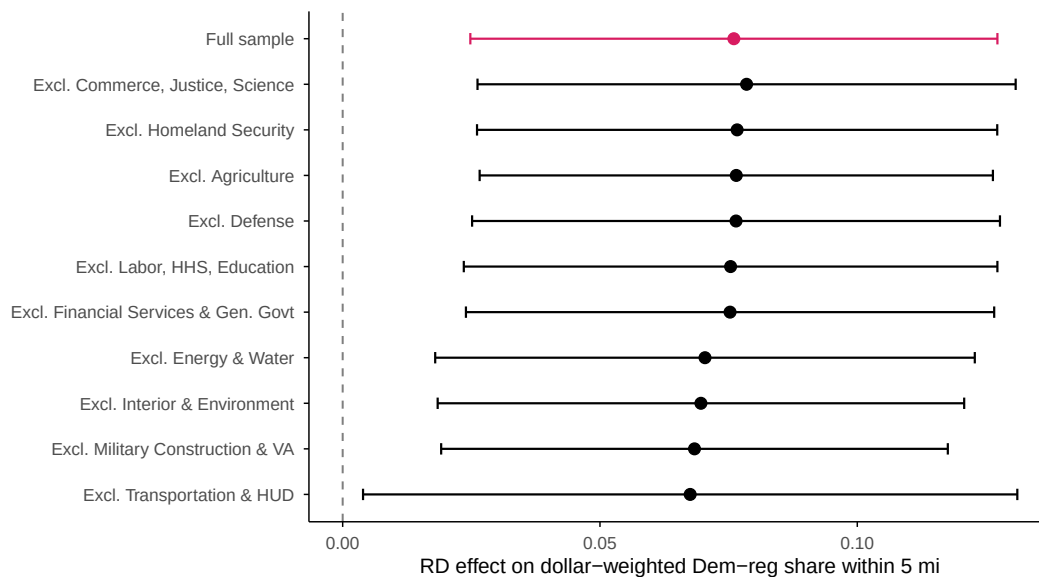


Figure H.2 reverses the exercise. Rather than restricting requests to a single subcommittee, we re-estimate the pooled design after excluding each subcommittee’s requests in turn, recomputing the dollar-weighted outcome from the remaining projects. The estimates range from 6.7 to 7.8 percentage points and remain statistically significant at the 5% level in every case, so the pooled effect is not driven by the requests of any single subcommittee. The two largest movements come from excluding Transportation–HUD, the largest subcommittee by requested dollars, and Military Construction and Veterans Affairs, whose project locations are constrained by existing military installations; both leave the estimate at 6.7 percentage points.

Figure H.2 – Effect of Electing a Democrat on the Dollar-Weighted Democratic Registration Share Near Earmark Requests, Excluding One Subcommittee at a Time (5-Mile Radius). Each point is the pooled CCT regression-discontinuity estimate of β_1 from Equation 2 after excluding earmark requests directed to the labeled subcommittee, with the district-year outcome recomputed from the remaining requests; horizontal bars are robust 95% confidence intervals. The “Full sample” estimate (red) matches Figure 5.



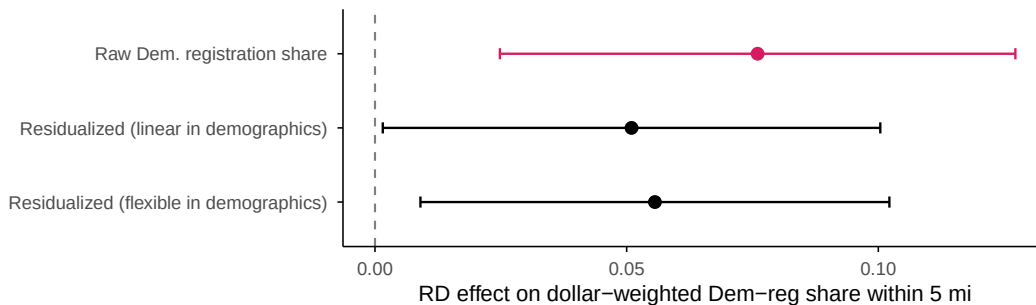
I Targeting of Residualized Partisanship

This appendix assesses whether the co-partisan targeting we document in Section 6.2.1 could instead reflect legislators targeting a *combination* of socio-demographic characteristics that together predict partisanship, even though no single characteristic responds to a narrow Democratic win in Figure 9. To do so, we purge the outcome of demographic content before estimation. Specifically, we regress the two-party Democratic registration share within 5 miles of each earmark request on the four socio-demographic covariates from Figure 9—the share of non-white residents, population density (logged), the share of residents holding a bachelor’s degree or more, and the share in poverty—across all recipient sites. We then retain the residual (the component of local partisanship that these characteristics cannot predict) and reconstruct the dollar-weighted district-year outcome in Equation 1 from the residualized measure and re-estimate our main regression discontinuity.

We implement the first-stage regression two ways. The linear specification enters the four covariates directly ($R^2 = 0.64$). The flexible specification replaces each covariate with indicators for the deciles of its sample distribution and fully interacts the race and density deciles, so that any nonlinear or joint urban-minority gradient is absorbed nonparametrically ($R^2 = 0.67$).

Figure I.1 reports the results, alongside the raw-outcome estimate on the identical estimation sample. Narrowly electing a Democrat shifts the dollar-weighted Democratic registration share of requested projects by 7.5 percentage points in the raw data ($p = 0.003$), by 5.0 points after linear residualization ($p = 0.040$), and by 5.5 points after flexible residualization ($p = 0.018$). Roughly three-quarters of the raw targeting effect therefore operates on partisanship itself rather than on the portion of partisanship predictable from socio-demographic characteristics—individually or in combination. These results reinforce the conclusion of Section 6.2: demographic targeting cannot account for the partisan favoritism we identify.

Figure I.1 – Effect of Electing a Democrat on Raw and Residualized Democratic Registration Share Near Earmark Requests, 5-Mile Radius. Each point is the CCT regression-discontinuity estimate of β_1 from Equation 2 on the dollar-weighted outcome named on the left; horizontal bars are robust 95% confidence intervals. The “Raw” row (red) uses the Democratic registration share within 5 miles of requested projects; the residualized rows replace it with the residual from a project-level regression of that share on the four socio-demographic covariates in Figure 9, entered linearly or flexibly (decile indicators, with race and density deciles fully interacted). All three rows use the identical estimation sample.



For reference, Figure I.2 reports the project-level correlations between the Democratic

registration share and each socio-demographic covariate, which motivate both this exercise and the placebo analysis in Section 6.2.1, and Table I.1 reports the raw RD point estimates underlying Figure 9 in each outcome’s native units.

Figure I.2 – Correlation Between Democratic Registration Share and Placebo Neighborhood Characteristics. Each point reports the Pearson correlation, across earmark requests filed in FY2022–FY2026, between the Democratic registration share and one placebo characteristic—the non-white share, population density, the share of residents with a bachelor’s degree or greater, and the share of residents in poverty—each measured within five miles of the request. All four placebos are positively correlated with Democratic registration, so a legislator who targeted any of them rather than partisanship directly could still shift requests toward more Democratic-leaning areas. Figure 9 shows that electing a Democrat significantly shifts requests toward co-partisan areas but not toward these placebo characteristics.

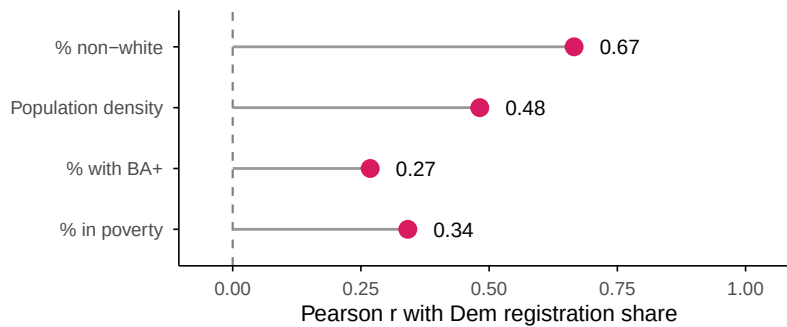


Table I.1 – Raw RD Point Estimates Underlying Figure 9. Regression-discontinuity estimates of the effect of narrowly electing a Democrat on each Figure 9 outcome, in the outcome’s native units (including population density). Because the units differ across rows, the point estimates are not comparable across rows; Figure 9 places them on a common percentile scale.

Outcome	RD estimate	Robust SE	<i>N</i>
Dem. registration share	0.076***	0.026	993
% non-white	0.012	0.044	993
Population density	85.5	325.6	993
% with BA+	−0.000	0.017	993
% in poverty	0.007	0.010	993

Note: Raw Calonico, Cattaneo, and Titiunik (2014) RD estimates of the effect of narrowly electing a Democrat, in each outcome’s native units: registration and demographic outcomes are shares (proportions in $[0,1]$), while population density is registered persons per square mile. Because the units differ across rows, the point estimates are not comparable across rows; Figure 9 places them on a common percentile scale. District-regime-clustered robust bias-corrected standard errors in the third column. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

J Grid Cell Construction

We overlay the fifty states and D.C. with a single national grid of 5×5 mile cells using the US National Atlas Equal Area projection. Because the projection is equal-area, every cell covers exactly 25 square miles. The resulting gridded panel contains 144,057 distinct cells and 720,169 cell-FY observations over FY2022–FY2026. Of these, 5,391 cells and 11,263 cell-FYs receive at least one earmark during our sample period.

For each cell, we calculate five time-invariant characteristics of its political and socio-demographic profile. *Non-white share* is one minus white-alone population over total population, from the 2020 Decennial Census PL 94-171 redistricting file at block-group level (mean 0.298). *Population density* is total population per square mile, from the 2020 Decennial Census PL 94-171 redistricting file at block-group level divided by the cell’s area (mean 87.9, median 3.5). *Share with a BA or higher* is persons holding a bachelor’s, master’s, professional or doctoral degree among those aged 25 and over, from the 2019–2023 ACS five-year estimates, table B15002 (mean 0.214). *Poverty share* is persons below 100 % of the federal poverty level over the poverty universe, from the 2019–2023 American Community Survey five-year estimates, table C17002 (mean 0.144). Finally, *Democratic registration share* is registered Democrats over registered Democrats plus Republicans, from the L2 national voter file, 2021 snapshot, geocoded to individual addresses (mean 0.377). The census and ACS measures are non-missing for 99.6% of cell-FYs. Democratic registration share is defined only where a cell holds at least 25 Democratic or Republican registrants, since smaller denominators produce mechanical rates of zero or one, and is therefore computable for 45.6% of cell-FYs.⁴⁵ Our retained sample covers 99.6% of all cell-assigned earmark dollars and 99.1% of cells that ever receive an earmark.

Each grid cell is then assigned to the congressional district containing its centroid using TIGER/Line cartographic boundary files: the 2021 vintage for the 117th Congress, the 2022 vintage for the 118th, and the 2024 vintage for the 119th.⁴⁶ The assignment is recomputed for each Congress to allow for changes in party representation. We leverage two sources of variation in party representation: electoral turnover, when a district switches parties, and the 2022 decennial redistricting process, which reassigned some cells from Democratic to Republican representation or vice versa. In other words, while a cell’s political and socio-demographic profile is fixed, the party representing it can change either because its district elects a member of the other party or because redistricting moves the cell into a different district. Across the full grid, 36,332 cells and 181,658 cell-FYs experience a change in party representation, and 926 cells and 4,630 cell-FYs both receive at least one earmark and experience such a change.

Our final estimation sample, which drops sparsely populated cells as well as districts where we cannot compute a Democratic vote margin, contains 53,104 cells and 211,161 cell-

⁴⁵The excluded cells are overwhelmingly sparsely populated: their median population is 15, against 754 in the cells we retain.

⁴⁶A cell that straddles more than one district is assigned in its entirety to the district containing its centroid, rather than split or weighted. Ten district-Congress observations contain no grid cell centroid because of their small geographic size: MA-7 and NY-14 in the 117th Congress, NY-12 in the 118th and 119th Congresses, and NY-10 and NY-13 in all three Congresses. We omit these cases rather than assign them a cell that already belongs to a neighboring district. Together, they account for only 0.41% of cell-level requested dollars, and their omission has no effect on the reported point estimates at three decimal places.

FYs, covering 93.5% of cells that ever receive an earmark and 89.3% of cell-assigned earmark dollars. Of these, 4,630 cells and 21,376 cell-FYs experience a change in party representation, of which 668 cells and 3,168 cell-FYs receive an earmark. Table J.1 reports the number of cells and cell-FYs at each stage of this sample construction.

Table J.1 – Grid Cell Sample Construction

	# Cells	# Cell-FYs	% Earmark Dollars
Total	144,057	720,169	100.0
Experience Change in Party Representation	36,332	181,658	13.0
Receive Any Earmark	5,391	11,263	100.0
Computable Socio-Demographic/Political Variables	65,698	328,466	99.6
Estimation Sample	53,104	211,161	89.3
Sample with Identifying Variation	4,630	21,376	10.0

K Donor Targeting in Grid-Cell Panel

Figure K.1 extends the grid cell analysis from Section 6.2.2 to compare targeting by voter registration and donor partisanship. Panels A and B enter the Democratic-win interactions with registration and the Democratic share of contribution dollars separately, while Panel C includes both. Panel B shows that legislators do not appear to target co-partisan donors, and controlling for Democratic registration share in Panel C does not change these conclusions.

Figure K.1 – Within-District Earmark Targeting by Party Registration and Donor Partisanship. Points report Democratic-win interactions for a move from the 25th to the 75th percentile of each characteristic, in percentage points. All specifications include Democratic representation, the contribution measure’s main effect, the four demographic interactions, and grid cell and fiscal year fixed effects. Bars show 95% confidence intervals clustered by district election.

